

Violence in Silence: The Plight of *Birangana* in Post-independence

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Sexual assault was one of the many violent crimes that took place in Bangladesh during the Liberation War of 1971 which resulted in the nation's independence. The Pakistani army targeted millions of Bengali women and used sexual violence as a weapon of war against them, aiming to abolish traditional culture and destroy their dignity. In post-independence Bangladesh, these victims were given the title *birangana*, which translates into English as brave women. Despite numerous witnesses, the instances of women subjected to sexual violence were not accurately documented. The national narrative of the event remains male-centric. This gap, a form of historical silence, has influenced the lives of *biranganas*, making it difficult to reveal their personal history in post-independence Bangladesh. This master's research utilizes an archival method, specifically examining historical photographs, newspaper cuttings, and published oral testimonies to investigate the memories and experiences of these women in post-independence Bangladesh. This thesis argues that the initiatives taken to restore them in society are layered with silences, including the unrecognized sacrifices they made, the economic injustices they faced, and their constant struggles for official recognition. This thesis relates these layers of silence that continue to exist in society to various forms of violence that often go beyond observable forms. Drawing upon the scholarship of renowned historian Michel-Rolph Trouillot, it explores the phenomenon of historical silence while also relying on the insights of Pierre Bourdieu and Johan Galtung regarding the concept of violence. In order to understand these layered silences against *biranganas* in Bangladesh today, I argue that one needs to understand the multiple forms of violence that they have encountered every day and how the events of 1971 shape their lives.

Lay Summary

Biranganas, which translates to “war heroines,” are the women who were subjected to sexual violence by the Pakistani army in the 1971 Liberation War of Bangladesh. Although the history of the 1971 war has been documented from different perspectives, stories of *biranganas* remain limited and inadequate. The research aims to explore the memories and experiences of *biranganas* in post-independence Bangladesh, highlighting how their sufferings are often overlooked and deeply embedded in historical silence.

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“Trigger Warning”

This thesis contains graphic photographs of sexual violence and combat. Please engage in self-care as you read this thesis.

Introduction

“I had to experience the tragedy that 1971 brought, not just for myself but for the entire country. I felt unwanted in the community after Bangladesh gained independence because I had experienced severe physical and mental harassment (by Pakistani army). I've received harsh

criticism. I experienced horrific abuse. I work with and sculpt the bark of trees as they signify to me the abandoned, like I was after 1971—abandoned, ridiculed, humiliated and treated with contempt.”

-Ferdousi Priyabhashini in “Narir Kotha (Women & War)”¹

In 1999, the renowned Bangladeshi sculptor Ferdousi Priyabhashini became one of the first women to publicly declare that the Pakistani army had sexually assaulted her during the 1971 Liberation War of Bangladesh.²In order to promote gender justice for all sexually assaulted victims of the 1971 War including herself, Priyabhashini shared her painful experiences in numerous national and international public venues.³In 2000, she took part in the Tokyo Tribunal and provided a brief testimony describing her experience as a victim.⁴In a culture where sexual assault victims were advised to keep their experiences private out of respect for the country and out of fear for their own safety, Priyabhashini’s decision to come forward was a brave one and a remarkable action. What the perpetrators had done to women like her was seen as a collective humiliation. Before passing away in 2018, Ferdousi Priyabhashini made a great impact on public awareness by sharing her traumatic experiences and shedding light on the similar experiences endured by numerous women that had been ignored for a long time.

¹ Tareque Masud and Catherine Masud, “Narir Kotha (Women & War),” filmed 2000, YouTube, 25:00. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BsazbwBGS0M>

² Nayanika Mookherjee, “Lessons of consent and critique from Ferdousi Priyabhashini,” *The Daily Star*, March 15, 2018, <https://www.thedailystar.net/opinion/tribute/lessons-consent-and-critique-ferdousi-priyabhashini-1548142> ³

Bina D’Costa and Sara Hossain, “Redress for Sexual Violence Before the International Crimes Tribunal in Bangladesh: Lessons from History, and Hopes for the Future,” *Criminal Law Forum* 21, no. 2 (2010): 342. ⁴ Shaheen Akhter, Suraiya Begum, Hameeda Hossein, Sultana Kamal and Meghna Guhathakurta, *Narir Ekattor O Juddhoporoborti Koththo Kahini* (Dhaka: Ain-O-Salish-Kendro, 2001), 135.

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Like Priyabhashini, millions of girls and women were targeted by the Pakistani army in the 1971

Liberation War of Bangladesh.⁵ Given the religious, social, and cultural context, the Pakistani

army conducted a widespread campaign of sexual violence on Bengali women with the aim of abolishing Bengali traditional culture by destroying the dignity of its women. During the Liberation War, there was also a strategy to completely destroy the minority groups, especially Hindus. The perpetrators deliberately targeted the women who would become victims of sexual assault in 1971, often selecting them based on their ethnicity or religion. The Pakistani military specifically targeted women during the war due to their affiliation with the enemy's community.⁶

Sexual violence during 1971 was implemented as an intentional military strategy, either through the establishment of sexual assault camps or through random attacks on women's houses and surrounding areas. The Pakistani military effectively transformed schools and factories into centres where sexual violence took place.⁷ Women were tortured and subjected to unimaginable brutality. Pakistani armies and local collaborators abducted many women, held them captive in those camps, and assaulted them repeatedly during the nine months of the war. Their hair was chopped off, they were tied down and repeatedly tortured, forced to take off their *sari*⁸ and wear rags or men's shirts. These women were even denied food, leaving many of them to starve to death.⁹ Sexual violence was also employed in such a way that it disconnected women's ties to their history. Mostly, a desire for power and control was the driving force. The act of sexually assaulting women during the war exemplified the ability of the Pakistani army to exert

⁵ Susan Brownmiller, *Against Our Will: Men, Women and Rape* (New York: Fawcett Columbine, 1975), 80–81.

⁶ Imtiaz Ahmed, *Recognizing the 1971 Bangladesh Genocide: An Appeal for Rendering Justice* (Dhaka: Nympha Publication, 2022), 26.

⁷ Imtiaz Ahmed, *Recognizing the 1971 Bangladesh Genocide*, 28.

⁸ *Sari* is a style of clothing worn traditionally by women from South Asia that consists of a length of silk or cotton that has been intricately draped around the body.

⁹ Yasmin Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh: Remembering 1971* (NC: Duke University Press, 2011), 49.

women to recover a sense of belonging after the war.¹⁰ In postwar Bangladesh, these victims had to live in a society where their collective memory was shaped by silence—their inability to publicly speak out about their experiences for fear of reprisal. Their personal history became a well-guarded secret that could not be revealed.¹¹ I am referring to the concept of secrecy as a form of historical silence that influences the way sexual violence in 1971 is collectively remembered.

Unfortunately, the instances of women being subjected to sexual violence were not accurately documented despite the presence of numerous witnesses. Moreover, most of them refrained from revealing their traumatic experiences due to societal stigmas and familial obstacles. Following independence, significant attempts were undertaken by the government, social organizations, and individuals to reintegrate these women into society and ensure that they were remembered as its valued members. The primary and most important initiative was honouring them with the title “*birangana*.” Implemented in 1972, right after the war’s conclusion, there were two programs aimed at rehabilitating the victims and facilitating the adoption of “war babies.” Furthermore, in 1992, the “Peoples’ Tribunal for the Elimination of War Criminals and Collaborators” conducted an unofficial public hearing, during which women who had survived sexual violence in 1971 provided testimonies for the first time.¹²

The Awami League government, which came into power after independence, implemented measures to reintegrate *biranganas* into society. The first ever initiative to acknowledge these women was giving them the title “*birangana*,” which translates into English

¹⁰ Saikia, *Women, war and the making of Bangladesh*, 49.

¹¹ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 52.

¹² D’Costa and Hossain, “Redress,” 333.

as “war heroines,” “the brave ones,” or “the blameless ones.” Immediately after achieving victory on December 16th, 1971, the Bangladesh government honoured them with the title in an attempt to acknowledge their sacrifices.¹³ On December 22, 1971, A. H. M. Kamruzzamman, the home minister of the interim government of Bangladesh, announced that all women who have endured severe torture by the occupying Pakistani army in the previous nine months will be acknowledged as *biranganas* of the Bangladesh liberation movement.¹⁴ The term gained popularity as government speeches, newspaper articles and rehabilitation projects started using it frequently. The word “*birangana*” is a combination of the Bengali words “*bir*” and “*ongona*,” which literally means “brave women.” Although terms like “*mohila muktijoddha*” (women freedom fighters) and “*shaheed*” (martyrs) were also popularized to describe women’s contribution to the war, the term *birangana* specifically referred to those women who were sexually assaulted during the 1971 war.¹⁵ The term was further popularized by the newly elected Prime Minister Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. Sheikh Mujib hoped that, through this recognition, a space would be created for women to claim their contribution in the war.¹⁶ However, the word “*birangana*” is also a powerful example of wordplay that highlights the historical marginalization of women. When replaced with “a,” it becomes “*barangana*,” referring to a beautiful woman associated with the marketplace or brothel. This shift in meaning highlights the challenges faced by *biranganas* in escaping societal perception in post-independence Bangladesh.¹⁷

¹³ Nayanika Mookherjee, “The raped woman as a horrific sublime and the Bangladesh war of 1971”, *Journal of material culture* 20, no. 4 (2015): 381.

¹⁴ Nayanika Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound: Sexual Violence, Public Memories and the Bangladesh War of 1971* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2015), 130.

¹⁵ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, 133–134.

¹⁶ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, 130–131.

¹⁷ Fayeza Hasanat, *The Voices of War Heroines: Sexual Violence, Testimony, and the Bangladesh Liberation War* (Boston, Brill, 2022), 10.

However, in postwar Bangladesh, *biranganas* were dehumanized and treated as mere objects by their countrymen. They were shunned due to societal stigma. They faced challenges and barriers in their efforts to rebuild their lives as liberated citizens. These women were socially ostracized and faced many forms of injustice in a newly liberated nation. Their responses were marked by a mixture of silence, resilience, trauma and abandonment. For a long period, their stories remained untold and unrecognized in the official historiography of the war. Here, official historiography represents public and classroom discussion, print media, publications and literary and cultural initiatives. Moreover, aside from a few recent works that will be examined in this thesis, there has been a greater silence around this topic than the war itself due to the lack of any scholarly work specifically addressing these women from 1971 to 1991.

It was only during the 1990s that some human rights organizations and scholars attempted to document *biranganas*. Bangladeshi feminists, journalists, and human rights activists began recording the oral histories of war heroines, especially those who belonged to poor and middle-class families. Nilima Ibrahim in her 1994–95 pioneering work *Ami Birangana Bolchi* (translated into English as *This is the War Heroine Speaking*) published the oral testimonies of seven *biranganas* for the first time. The purpose of this documentation was to gather evidence that could be used in the trial of Bengali collaborators who assisted the Pakistani army in the war and committed sexual violence. Consequently, newspapers in the 1990s often featured photographs and stories about war heroines.¹⁸

In 1992 and during 1994–95, some victims began to share their stories, breaking their long silence. In the years that followed, more and more women came forward to give testimony.

¹⁸Nayanika Mookherjee, "History and the Birangona," *The Daily Star*, June 21, 2021, <https://www.thedailystar.net/in-focus/news/history-and-the-birangona-2114681>

The resurgence of accounts detailing women's experiences of wartime sexual violence occurred within a specific context.¹⁹ This context included the reintegration of collaborators, the absence of trials for collaborators of the Pakistani army involved in the killing of intellectuals during the war, the increase in *fatwas*,²⁰ the international portrayal of the Liberation War as a civil war within the framework of Cold War politics and human rights discourse, the necessity of transmitting the history of the war to younger generations, and consequently, the failure to recognize its genocidal origins.²¹

In an effort to honour the *biranganas*' contributions, the Bangladeshi government introduced a number of initiatives in the last 15 years, one of which was the establishment of the International Crimes Tribunal (ICT), a domestic court established under the 2009 amendment to the International Crimes (Tribunals) Act 1974. The primary aim of the Tribunal was to prosecute individuals accountable for war crimes. It was formed to provide justice to those who were harmed by the conflict. There have been extensive debates, conflicts, and disputes over the ICT trials and their reliability. Notwithstanding the various challenges, this is considered a crucial measure in addressing past injustices suffered by the *biranganas* in 1971.²²

After forty years of independence, in the 2010s, Bangladesh finally made an effort to officially recognize these women. After women's rights activists called for *biranganas* to be declared freedom fighters, the Parliament of Bangladesh approved a proposal to upgrade the status of *birangana* to freedom fighters. In October 2015, the Bangladesh government for the

¹⁹ Mookherjee, “History and the Birangona.”

²⁰ A *fatwa* is a formal decree or interpretation of Islamic law provided by a certified legal scholar, known as a mufti, in the context of Islam. *Fatwas* are typically issued as a response to inquiries posed by people or Islamic courts. Although *fatwas* are regarded as authoritative, they are typically not regarded as legally binding rulings. ²¹ Mookherjee, “History and the Birangona.”

²² D’Costa and Hossain, “Redress,” 331.

first time declared 41 *biranganas* freedom fighters.²³ As of the end of 2020, there were a total of 400 *biranganas* who were officially recognized as freedom fighters. In 2021, 16 more women were added to the list at the 73rd meeting of the National Freedom Fighter Council, taking the total number to 416.²⁴

Due to the lack of historical research, the stories of *biranganas* in post-independence Bangladesh are incomplete and fragmented. Despite all the efforts undertaken to recognize them, the nation’s memory of the war remains skewed, with records of women’s subjugation being scant and the official history remaining male-centric. In Yasmin Saikia’s words, the disengagement with women’s trauma in the existing official history creates a “yawning gap” that makes 1971 almost impossible to understand.²⁵ The very fact of women’s involvement in the war is also compromised in collective memory. The existing official historiography focuses on external-level events and actions, such as the tactics used by freedom fighters and enemies, combat operations, leaders and campaigns.²⁶ These elements dominate the memory and history of the war. In this way, awareness of the violent past is forgotten and lost. The forgotten memories belong to these women who were not directly involved in the conflict, but whose bodies were used as a site on which power was inscribed.²⁷

The history of Bangladesh and 1971 has been shaped by many different political regimes over the years. Changes have been made to historiography based on differing ideas and

influences from religious and military authorities. The reintegration of several pro-Pakistani

²³ Syed Samiul Basher Anik, “41 Birangonas get Freedom Fighter status,” *Dhaka Tribune*, October 13, 2015, <http://archive.dhakatribune.com/bangladesh/2015/oct/13/41-birangonas-get-freedom-fighter-status> ²⁴ Tribune Desk, “Government recognizes 16 more Birangonas as freedom fighters,” *Dhaka Tribune*, June 12, 2021, <https://archive.dhakatribune.com/bangladesh/government-affairs/2021/06/12/government-recognizes-16-more-birangonas-as-freedom-fighters>

²⁵ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 4–5.

²⁶ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 5.

²⁷ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 4–5.

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political figures who were directly involved in the atrocities carried out against Bengalis in 1971 created two competing historical narratives in Bangladesh. The official narrative and the actual experience of the people have become increasingly distinct as a result.²⁸ Moreover, politicians in post-independence Bangladesh deliberately misrepresented the memory of sexual violence against Bengali women to provoke hatred towards Pakistan and local collaborators. In this political atmosphere, Bengali men were branded as heroic warriors and local collaborators as traitors. Thus, a detailed insight into the atrocities committed against women in 1971 was missing from the national political memory. Men once more used the image of the victimized woman to incite retaliation.²⁹ As a result, these women were exposed to further violence through silence.

In many ways, this thesis asks the central question of how historical silence is created in Bangladesh regarding the plight of *birangonas* and why it persists in various forms of violence. I argue that the very initiatives taken to restore *birangonas* in society are themselves layered with silences: silences of those unrecognized sacrifices these women made, the economic injustices they had to face in their everyday lives, their constant struggle for official recognition as freedom fighters by the state, and many other forms of silencing associated with the challenges of archiving documents and oral testimonies. I argue that all these actions and inactions created a

vacuum in the formation of collective memory of the war in present day Bangladesh and contributed to various forms of misrecognized violence that were experienced by these women and which occurred routinely in familiar spaces. In the process, I aim to develop an archival approach to understanding the knowledge gap that ignores the creation of the violence that takes

²⁸ Bina D'Costa, "Birangona: Bearing Witness in War and 'Peace'," in *Of The Nation Born: The Bangladesh Papers*, ed. Hameeda Hossain and Amena Mohsin (New Delhi: Zubaan Publishers Pvt. Ltd, 2016), 74. ²⁹ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 75–76.

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place in the everyday lives of these victims and eventually shapes the collective memory of the war in Bangladesh.

The concept of historical silence is not just about the absence of information or the fictionalization of the past in postwar Bangladesh. As supported by my research, historical silence is a deliberate and systematic process where knowledge about events like sexual violence in 1971 is manipulated, rewritten, and intertwined to create a disjointed collective memory. I draw on the theoretical concept of historical silence by pioneering historian Michel-Rolph Trouillot to argue that these silences do not just happen on their own, but are created purposefully in historical documents and can be traced by analyzing these documents. This thesis follows the headway made by many scholars who have followed in Trouillot's footsteps, but it is particularly influenced by his claim that inequitable power systems in historical narratives reinforce "bundles of silence." These silences are not only present in academic histories but also in primary sources, archival materials, and in the ways that societies remember the past, recount stories from the past, and determine the historical significance of events.³⁰

I use three types of archival materials to locate different forms of violence in these women's lives outside of the event of sexual violence that took place in 1971. First, I examine historical

photographs of the victims in order to identify symbolic meanings associated with their representation that contribute to indirect forms of violence. Second, I tackle newspaper cuttings from three significant decades and present how silence is structured in news media. And third, I draw on published oral testimonies by Nilima Ibrahim and Ain-O-Salish Kendra³¹ to uncover

³⁰ Michel-Rolph Trouillot, *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History* (Boston, Mass.: Beacon Press, 1995), 27.

³¹ Ain-O-Salish-Kendra (ASK) is a national legal aid and human rights organization in Bangladesh that provides legal and social support to the disempowered (particularly women), unprivileged children and workers.

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ingrained silences about war heroines that often go unnoticed. I argue that such ingrained silence in oral testimonies reformulates archival violence. I analyze the notion that the historical silence about *biranganas* is a process that promotes violence and can be influenced by the absence or misrepresentation of archival documents. Furthermore, I assert that the collective memory of the war is shaped by the way popular literary, electronic, and visual institutions, and the state representation of these women, demonstrating an omission of key details about them.

Context of the 1971 Liberation War of Bangladesh

The political, cultural, and socioeconomic forces that developed over decades, giving rise to a climax of complaints and demands for autonomy and independence, are profoundly rooted in the setting of Bangladesh's 1971 Liberation War. The partition of the Indian subcontinent in 1947 was a momentous event that had profound effects on this region's political landscape. While India emerged as a secular state, Pakistan chose to overtly emphasize its religious nationalism.³² Before 1971, Bangladesh was an occupied territory of Pakistan named East Pakistan. Pakistan was divided into two unequal halves, namely West Pakistan and East Pakistan, separated by culture and religion. West Pakistan was dominated by Muslim Punjabis, whereas

East Pakistan was populated by a diverse Muslim-Hindu Bengali community.³³ The start of the conflict was caused by several important factors on which I elaborate next.

As East Pakistan had both Hindu minorities and Muslim Bengalis, the western region looked down upon their eastern neighbours by calling the area “a low-lying land of low-lying people” who contaminated the region with their non-Muslim values.³⁴ The notion of a Muslim

³² Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 34.

³³ Nitin Pai, “The 1971 East Pakistan Genocide - A Realist Perspective,” *International Crimes Strategy Forum*, (2008): 1.

³⁴ Pai, “The 1971 East Pakistan Genocide,” 1.

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homeland played a pivotal role in the establishment of the Dominion of Pakistan, acting as the primary basis for national identity. However, conflicts rooted in ethnicity rather than religion complicated the early stages of establishing the new nation of Pakistan.³⁵ The two separate entities were not only geographically different but also displayed cultural and linguistic differences. The Pakistani authorities held a conviction that Hindu culture served as an influence on the Bengali Muslims of East Pakistan, who exhibited a significant emphasis on literature, music, and dance. They deemed the Islamic rituals of Bengalis as “inferior and impure.”³⁶ The larger fight for autonomy saw a key forerunner in the Language Movement of 1952.³⁷ The Urdu speaking elite primarily identified themselves as Muslims rather than Bengalis and followed an aristocratic cultural and religious model influenced by Arabic and North Indian traditions.³⁸ The West Pakistani authorities imposed the decision to make Urdu the national language. The majority Bengali population refused to accept it. This resistance sparked riots and bloodshed in the 1950s.³⁹ Bengali-speaking East Pakistanis soon realized that they had been oppressed as a colony of the richer West Pakistan.

The sense of superiority expressed by West Pakistan fostered the implementation of certain

discriminatory policies by the Pakistani government, leading to an internal conflict. One example is the discrimination in resource sharing that generated resentment among Bengalis. During the decades between 1950 and 1960, East Pakistan maintained a favourable trade balance

³⁵ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 35.

³⁶ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, 33.

³⁷ In the old East Bengal, which was renamed East Pakistan in 1952, the Language Movement of 1952 was a political movement. The movement started in 1948, came to a head with the killings of several students from Dhaka on February 21, 1952, and culminated with Bangla being declared one of Pakistan's official languages. The central leaders and the Urdu-speaking intellectuals of Pakistan declared that only *Urdu* would be the state language of Pakistan, allowing for its use in official matters; the continuation of its use as a medium of instruction; its use in media, currency, and stamps; and the maintenance of its writing in the Bengali script. This was done despite Bengalis being the overwhelming majority in East Pakistan.

³⁸ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, 33.

³⁹ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 35.

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with foreign countries. Although responsible for almost 60% of Pakistan's foreign revenue, East Pakistan constituted just under 30% of its total imports. East Pakistan consistently faced a trade imbalance with West Pakistan. It served as a captive market for the industries of West Pakistan, leading to a notable gap in per capita income between the two regions. Between 1959 and 1960, the mean income of individuals residing in West Pakistan surpassed that of their counterparts in the eastern region by a margin of 32%. Nevertheless, after a decade, this disparity had escalated to 61%.⁴⁰ Accordingly, the capital city remained located in West Pakistan, functioning as the central hub for government spending and administrative activities. East Pakistanis were also excluded from participating in decision-making processes. Although the East comprised 56% of Pakistan's population, Bengalis were not adequately represented in the army.⁴¹

The Awami League emerged as the main opposition party in East Pakistan that mobilized against the oppression by West Pakistan. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman led the Awami League and proposed a six-point formula in 1966 that became a pivotal document in the struggle against exploitation by the West. It was intended to grant autonomy and self-determination to East

Pakistan. The central government led by General Ayub Khan suppressed the six-point demand movement and arrested Sheikh Mujib in a conspiracy case. Soon, the people of East Pakistan demanded Sheikh Mujib's release and mobilized against the Ayub regime. As a consequence,

Sheikh Mujib was released in early 1969. A large-scale movement forced Ayub Khan's resignation and General Yahya Khan took over. Yahya promised to transfer power to elected representatives after holding a general election, which took place on December 7, 1970. This

⁴⁰ Shireen Hasan Osmany, *Bangladeshi Nationalism: History of Dialectics and Dimensions* (Dhaka: University Press Limited, 1992), 114–17.

⁴¹ Bina D'Costa, *Nationbuilding, Gender and War Crimes in South Asia* (New York: Routledge, 2011), 90.

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period marked a significant shift in power dynamics in Pakistan, with the military regime eventually giving way to a more democratic political setting.⁴²

In the 1970 general election, the Awami League under the leadership of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman achieved a significant victory by securing 160 out of 162 seats in East Pakistan. On the other hand, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, the founder of the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP), emerged victorious in West Pakistan.⁴³ The result of the election indicated that the Awami League would form the new government and Sheikh Mujib would become the Prime Minister of Pakistan. But the Pakistani military junta denied transferring power to Sheikh Mujib, as he was a Bengali. The dispute around power distribution and the decision to appoint Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as the prime minister intensified tensions, finally leading to military intervention against the Bengali majority in East Pakistan.⁴⁴ On March 7, 1971, Sheikh Mujib called upon the people to commence a noncooperation campaign as a strategy to attain the national liberation of East Pakistan from the Dominion of Pakistan.⁴⁵ The political tension between the two regions reached

its peak and a war broke out. However, the violence was not limited to clashes between men in armed organizations. Women, in particular, were disproportionately affected by the brutality, which led to many unarmed, non-resisting individuals of all ages being killed and maimed who had caused no harm to their assailants.⁴⁶

The Pakistani army committed a mass killing of innocent people on the dark of night on March 25, 1971 popularly known as “Operation Searchlight.” They targeted women and used sexual violence as a war strategy to dehumanize the whole population. It was not a unique

⁴² D’Costa, *Nationbuilding*, 90–92.

⁴³ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 38.

⁴⁴ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 38.

⁴⁵ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, 34.

⁴⁶ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 4.

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strategy because sexual violence has been a longstanding feature of war, including in recent wars in Kosovo (1998–99), Bosnia (1992–95), Croatia (1991–95), and Rwanda (1994). Moreover, this strategy was already endemic to South Asia, such as during the Partition (1947), when violence was inflicted upon women in two ways. First of all, men from different religions sexually assaulted women in an attempt to degrade the men of the women’s own religious group. Additionally, women faced violence from their own families in order to protect the community’s honour, often resulting in tragic outcomes such as suicide.⁴⁷

However, the reasons why Pakistan used sexual violence as a war instrument in 1971 differ from these other examples.⁴⁸ The Pakistani government ordered the army to impregnate Muslim and Hindu women from East Pakistan to turn the country into a “pure Pakistan” with a Muslim population. Here, we can relate this strategy to Claudia Card’s contention that sexual violence is a tool of genetic imperialism through forcible impregnation.⁴⁹ The sexual violence

imposed on Bengali women during the war was a strategy undertaken by Pakistani soldiers under order from their superiors to improve the genes of the Bengali Muslim people and populate Bangladesh with “pure” Muslims. Historically, colonial forces considered Bengali Muslims to be “Hinduized,” “half Muslims,” and “impure,” as evidenced in documents from the eighteenth century.⁵⁰

Card further explains that genetic dominance has a cross-cultural symbolic meaning among men in patriarchal societies, where sexual control is a sign of dominance.⁵¹ This

⁴⁷ Arunima Dey, “Violence against Women During the Partition of India: Interpreting Women and their Bodies in the Context of Ethnic Genocide,” *Spanish Journal of English Studies*, no. 37 (May 2017): 104. ⁴⁸ Saikia, *Women, war, and the making of Bangladesh*, 51.

⁴⁹ Claudia Card, “Rape as a Weapon of War,” *Hypatia* 11, no. 4 (Autumn 1996): 7.
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/3810388>

⁵⁰ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, 163.

⁵¹ Card, “Rape as a Weapon of War,” 11.

dominance extends beyond just women. Especially in times of conflict, it extends most significantly to other men who are perceived as the protectors of women. Women in patriarchal societies are therefore very easy targets in war. Sexual violence removes the most basic control over one’s personal bodily interactions with others. This control decides who is in charge. Such connections, however forced, may have an impact on the identities of survivors in terms of their future in patriarchal societies.⁵²

In the context of 1971, Bengali women were the easy targets and subjugating women sexually on a mass scale demonstrated the power of the all-male Pakistani army over the eastern population. The outcome was devastating and traumatic. Women were taken away from their homes to established camps where they were kept for days and tortured multiple times. The Pakistani army committed atrocities directed at women with a view to humiliating their enemies

both psychologically and morally. Women were used as sex slaves, their heads were shaved, and their bodies lied naked in the horror of those camps after they were assaulted.⁵³ In her 1975 classic book *Against Our Will: Men, Women and Rape*, Susan Brownmiller revealed that there was evidence that some women were sexually abused nearly 80 times in one night by the Pakistani army.⁵⁴ Although the accurate number of female victims remains a subject of ongoing debate, it is estimated that approximately 200,000 to 400,000 women were victims of sexual violence during the nine months of war in 1971.⁵⁵

⁵² Card, "Rape as a Weapon of War," 11.

⁵³ Steffi Deb, "The Liberation War of Bangladesh: Women and the Alternative Narratives of the War," *Journal of International Women's Studies* 22, no. 4 (2021): 82.

⁵⁴ Brownmiller, *Against Our Will*, 80.

⁵⁵ Brownmiller, *Against Our Will*, 80–81.

1971 War Narratives in Contemporary Bangladesh

The current historiography of *biranganas* in Bangladesh is a developing field of multidisciplinary research. However, there are still many unresolved questions regarding the organization and representation of violence in these women's lives in postwar Bangladesh, which are manifested through their silence. In addition to giving them a "voice," the trajectory of popular scholarship aims to ensure justice by holding those responsible for the sexual violence during the war accountable and by revealing the details of the violence *biranganas* endured in 1971 and the years that followed. Scholars like Nilima Ibrahim (*Ami Birangana Bolchi*, 1994–95), Bina D'Costa (*Nationbuilding: Gender and War Crimes in South Asia*, 2011), Yasmin Saikia (*Women, War, and the Making of Bangladesh: Remembering 1971*, 2011), and Nayanika

Mookherjee (*The Spectral Wound: Sexual Violence, Public Memories, and the Bangladesh War of 1971*, 2015) have conducted some of the most important research on this topic that delves into the historical background, social consequences, and long-term impacts on the lives of these women.

In various works, there has been a consistent emphasis on the significant role of women. However, despite efforts to bring attention to sexual violence as a means of highlighting the atrocities committed by the Pakistani army in 1971, this focus failed to make the women more visible. Instead, highlighting the victimization of these women served as a crucial method to raise awareness about the brutalities of the conflict and attract international support and aid for the war-torn economy.⁵⁶ According to prominent women's-rights activist Hameeda Hossain, there has been a lack of representation of women's experiences in the national narrative. The

⁵⁶ D'Costa, *Nationbuilding*, 111.

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graphic depictions of sexual violence were utilized in such a way that they represented women only as helpless beings.⁵⁷ The dominant history mainly includes stories of educated women from the middle or upper classes, particularly those who were political or social activists like Motia Chowdhury and Rokeya Rahman Kabir. However, the majority of women, who did not fit into these categories, have been overlooked and have quietly faded into the background of history.⁵⁸

A major challenge in constructing a meaningful historiography is the lack of relevant sources about *biranganas*. The narratives around these women have been influenced by the absence of personal testimonies. Additionally, the limited number of primary documents that are available to historians, authors, and organizations is almost entirely from the viewpoint of the

men as freedom fighters or other witnesses. Due to these limitations, the historiography of *biranganas* has not been able to portray their overall plight. In present day Bangladesh, sources related to these women are preserved in only a few institutions.

Bangladesh's existing archival structure is inadequate in terms of records related to the 1971 War, especially with regards to *biranganas*. No other government, other than the Awami League—the first one after independence—took any action to archive materials relating to 1971, which are spread throughout the world. The National Archive of Bangladesh has been compared by historian Muntasir Mamoon and deemed a “Directionless Organization” for its failure to store important documents.⁵⁹ Only a small number of national dailies from 1971—just sixteen in total—are kept in the National Archive, which is the largest archive in Bangladesh. It is important to note that materials related to *biranganas* are therefore difficult to locate in any

⁵⁷ Akhtar, Begum, Hossein, Kamal and Guhathakurata, *Narir Ekattor*, 10–12.

⁵⁸ D'Costa, *Nationbuilding*, 111.

⁵⁹ Partha Sankar Saha, “Muktijuddher dolil bolte kichu doinik potrika,” *Prothom Alo*, December 17, 2013, Ain-O Salish Kendra archive, BAH08027, Dhaka.

archive due to limited preservation.⁶⁰ The Liberation War Museum situated in Agargaon, Dhaka specializes in archiving war-related photographs, documents, books, and other materials. It has also built a gallery specially dedicated to *biranganas* that displays various historical photographs, wartime graffiti, and letters. Besides, Ain-Salish-Kendra situated in Lalmatia, Dhaka has also archived many important documents related to them.

The first work that collected the primary accounts of war heroines was Nilima Ibrahim's attempt to interview seven *biranganas* starting in 1992 for her book *Ami Birangana Bolchi*. In her book, Ibrahim draws on oral history interviews to write the distressing and frequently

unspoken tales of these women who endured great suffering throughout the war. Her goal was to give these women a voice, so they could share their struggles and experiences. Ibrahim's work serves to eliminate the negative perception associated with female victims and acknowledge their courage in the midst of unimaginable suffering. Ibrahim discusses a crucial part of the history of the war that had been disregarded for a long time in Bangladesh. By highlighting the pain of women and the lingering effects of sexual violence on their lives, she helps to depict a more comprehensive and inclusive narrative of the Liberation War.

Yasmin Saikia, Nayanika Mookherjee, and Bina D'Costa have recently attempted to unpack and publish the most well-known contemporary methods of *birangana* stories. In her 2011 book, *Women, War, and the Making of Bangladesh: Remembering 1971*, Indian author Yasmin Saikia applies and combines archival research and in-depth interviews to present an alternative historical narrative and question the prevailing account of women's history during the period of 1971. Saikia provides the reader with a comprehensive account of the struggle,

⁶⁰ Partha Sankar Saha, "Muktijuddher dolil bolte kichu doinik potrika," *Prothom Alo*, December 17, 2013, Ain-O-Salish Kendra archive, BAH08027, Dhaka.

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presenting the perspectives of common people and incorporating multiple testimonies from women who were subjected to sexual violence in the war. She is one of the first scholars active in the field today to publish testimonies from these victims and other affected women. The primary assertion she makes regarding the war heroines is that they were subjected to marginalization by the state. By highlighting the various forms of discrimination these women experienced, Saikia's work challenges the dominant narrative that often glorifies only men and leaves out *biranganas'* contribution to the war. She successfully established a system of justice for these women by utilizing their narratives and linking them to the historical context of South

Asian conflicts.

In her work, Bina D'Costa, another well-known historian on the subject of 1971, considers the greater political and social environment as well as the interaction between the state and war heroines. In her book *Nationbuilding: Gender and War Crimes in South Asia*, she prioritizes justice for these women by questioning various political attempts in postwar Bangladesh. By focusing on the current state of these women, D'Costa discusses various operations of the War Crimes Tribunal and argues that war heroines are not included in its procedures effectively. She goes further to claim that the existing transitional justice processes are flawed. D'Costa thus promotes an inclusive transitional justice approach for war heroines. She advocates for a war crimes tribunal focused on civil society and women's organization, where these victims can seek justice by being able to share their experiences.

On the other hand, Nayanika Mookherjee argues that government efforts like giving them the title *birangana* to honour war heroines, homogenize the experiences of these women. Although the attempt to honour them with the title *birangana* fosters public memory of these

women, they remain what she refers to as a “spectral wound” in people's minds. By spectral wound, Mookherjee refers to the harm caused by dominant depictions of *biranganas* as dehumanized victims and rejection by their communities. As a result, the variety of experiences of sexual violence that *biranganas* have endured is obliterated. In her book titled *The Spectral Wound: Sexual Violence, Public Memories, and the Bangladesh War of 1971*, Mookherjee employs a multi-sited method to thoroughly examine how the stories of war heroines are fabricated, which enabled an in-depth inquiry into the political, economic, ethical,

and intricate details of sexual violence in conflict.

Bina D'Costa further suggests that there are three competing narratives about 1971 that are dominant in Bangladesh.⁶¹ The first is the officially sanctioned government accounts of that era's political history, such as how freedom fighters (indicating only men) and eminent Bengali expatriates abroad fought the great liberation movement. Secondly, the numerous works of Bengali literature, both fictional and non-fictional, that make significant contributions to our understanding of the suffering of individuals in 1971. Thirdly, there are the experiences of survivors as shown by their narratives or by the secrets kept by families who suffered during the war, particularly those whose daughters and women were slaughtered, sexually abused, or sent to military camps to become pregnant. Together, these three narratives have developed dominant perceptions about what women and the general populace were like throughout the Liberation War.⁶²

Although many works have been conducted on *biranganas*, to understand them from social, political and cultural points of view, many aspects, such as their everyday struggles to

⁶¹ D'Costa, *Nationbuilding*, 104.

⁶² D'Costa, *Nationbuilding*, 104.

reintegrate into society, personal losses due to social stigmatization, and the unavailability of their primary accounts create many gaps in understanding their experiences. A notable gap exists in addressing the ongoing injustices faced by *biranganas* in Bangladesh, with a lack of literature focusing on the continued hardships they endure. As a result, the nation remembers these women only from the perspective of their struggles during the war and ignores knowledge of their continued present-day sacrifices.

With each passing day, *biranganas* and their stories are dying out. The collective memory of the war does not fully recognize the brutality these survivors went through. By collective memory, I refer to the act of remembering and depicting the historical event of 1971 and the sexual violence inflicted upon women.⁶³ New generations who did not experience the war or the consequences of the war are not fully aware of the silence regarding *biranganas*. This knowledge gap arises from the nation's inability to present a comprehensive and substantial narrative of the war to its citizens. Consequently, this has limited the development of a diverse and in-depth understanding of the war. I connect this limited development to the existing pattern of historical silence in Bangladeshi society, which exhibits itself through various forms of violence endured by *biranganas* in their everyday lives.

Description of Each Chapter

This thesis is organized around four chapters. In Chapter One, I describe the theory and methods used in this thesis, drawing on the theoretical concepts of historical silence, archival violence, and collective memory to establish the argument that there are a multiplicity of silences

⁶³ Vered Vinitzky-Seroussi and Chana Teeger, "Unpacking the Unspoken: Silence in Collective Memory and Forgetting," *Social Forces* 88, no. 3 (March 2010): 1103, <https://doi.org/10.1353/sof.0.0290>

regarding the state of the war heroines in contemporary Bangladesh. These concepts are important to uncover and problematize in order to better understand the role of archival documents in both empowering and re-silencing survivors of wartime sexual violence. This chapter provides a theoretical and historical overview of what "silence" is, how it works and impacts women in conflicts, and how different forms of silence can be found in historical

documents like photographs, oral testimonies, and newspaper articles, the three kinds of primary sources that I will explore in subsequent chapters.

This chapter also explains the role of collective memory in historical silence, by investigating how nations prohibit forming collective ideas about the past by erasing certain events (unintentionally or deliberately) and muting people related to them. It argues that memory formation is an act of remembering and forgetting. The collective memory of the war in Bangladesh thus remembers these women as mere victims, erasing or silencing in the process some crucial historical information about them. I then describe the methodology used in this thesis: how the data has been collected and analyzed. This chapter is thus important for understanding the basic concepts used in my analysis of historical silences regarding war heroines. It helps to demonstrate how the nation remembers them today, while also forgetting vital elements that shape the collective memory of the war.

In Chapter Two, I provide an analysis of the photographs used to document these women's lives. One of the modalities crucial for the act of remembering is photography. This chapter is based on the photographs that I collected from archives in Bangladesh, including the famous "hair photograph" by Naibuddin Ahmed, photographs of victims, and war babies. All of these photographs carry symbolic meanings, and this chapter explains the construction of the image of *biranganas* as a symbol of shame and silence through visual representation, which

elements of the patriarchal culture of Bangladesh perpetuate. This chapter also dives into the topic of war babies and their constant absence from historical documents, suggesting a knowledge gap regarding this issue. By connecting the symbolic meanings of photographs to theories regarding types of violence, this chapter argues that religious factors as well as social

stigmas around sexual violence played a major role in removing a large part of the historical record about the war. In turn, this removal creates a distorted memory of the past that looks incomplete without the proper inclusion of the victim's identity, their struggles and war babies who were later aborted or adopted by foreigners.

Chapter Three goes through a detailed examination of archival newspapers from three decades: the 1970s, 1990s, and 2010s. These three decades marked the emergence of *birangana* related issues in mainstream Bangladeshi newspapers, which also established how the past is interpreted by the media. This chapter argues that, in this process of interpretation, newspapers directly intervene in the historical process of restoring the status of *biranganas*. Some key findings suggest that, over the years, different patterns of silencing can be found in newspaper articles related to these women. Especially how only male freedom fighters have been glorified, creating a masculine representation of the war in the minds of people. In the 1990s, newspapers shifted their focus to bringing out personal stories of war heroines. Such positive journalism was able to break years of silence, inspiring many victims from rural areas to speak up about their victimization. During the 2010s, newspapers reported about the injustice victims experience in getting their official recognition due to the unequal power structure. All of these patterns of silencing and attempts to un-silence the buried wartime experiences of *biranganas*, I argue, can be understood using Michel-Rolph Trouillot's theoretical explanation of "layers of silencing." In

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addition to that, these newspaper articles perform the role of the social agent that shapes the way people understand and remember the *biranganas* as they are shared and received by the readers.

Chapter Four examines the published oral testimonies of war heroines in the books *Ami*

Birangana Bolchi by Nilima Ibrahim and *Narir Ekattor O Juddho Poroborti Kottho Kahini* by Ain-O-Salish-Kendra. Though these testimonies are considered essential for providing records of women's oral accounts for the first time in Bangladesh, they contain traces of silence, including a silencing of those facts that were never historicized, untold individual memories, and the disadvantages of oral history that initiate larger silence. This chapter looks closely at the intimate relationship between the victim and their loved ones and how silence prevails in their daily life decisions. Many women faced second victimization when well-meaning, but ineffective, rehabilitation programs by the government caused social ostracization and public shaming. Moreover, silence was persistent in the writers' community, as many decided not to write about those victims because that would result in repeat victimization. This chapter also explores how intersubjectivity can shape the story being told or rewritten. In the last part of the chapter, I argue that the failure to preserve primary evidence, such as interview transcripts, in archives creates another form of silencing and results in conflicting interpretations of the stories told by the survivors leading to a confusing collective understanding.

Chapter One: Theory and Method

Historically, the future was believed to be changeable, while the past was fixed. However,

new interpretations of the past are rewriting history, highlighting the complex relationship between memory and history. There was a blurry line between history and memory prior to the development of critical historical scholarship in the 18th and 19th centuries. Historiography primarily served the purpose of preserving the recollection of dynasties, churches, and states by defending the institutions of the ruling class. The memory selection criteria were established in accordance with the highest social standing that confirmed reputation and power, and occurrences that aligned with the views and interests of the ruling class. This maintained the distinction between history and memory by enforcing a collective identity that was validated over time by a particular power structure.⁶⁴

Memory relies on the societal frames that establish and retrieve recollections.⁶⁵ Humans form groups based on their social frameworks, which are structures of shared interests, principles, experiences, and stories. These groups include family, neighbourhood, peers, generations, nation, and culture. Shared behaviours and interactions that establish boundaries for inclusion and exclusion form the basis of every social group. In order to be a member of a collective group, it is necessary to both share and embrace the group's historical context, which extends beyond one's life span. Individuals engage in the group's historical narrative through cognitive learning and feelings of belonging. These events from the past cannot be "remembered," but rather, they must be committed to memory.⁶⁶

⁶⁴ Aleida Assmann, "Transformations between History and Memory," *Social Research* 75, no. 1 (2008): 56–58.

⁶⁵ Lewis Coser, *On Maurice Halbwachs* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992), 43. ⁶⁶ Assmann, "Transformations," 51–52.

This chapter describes the theoretical aspects of historical silence, drawing on Michel Rolph Trouillot's insights to explain how silence in archives is shaped by processes of

remembering and forgetting events. It also discusses the importance of collective memory in reconstructing the past for communities and individuals. Through historical examples, this chapter brings attention to the connection between silence and violence, shedding light on the impact of untold narratives. Additionally, this chapter engages with the methodology I employ in this thesis by detailing how archival documents on the Liberation War of 1971 were collected and by emphasizing why these are important to locate silence.

Collective Memory and Silence

Maurice Halbwachs, a French sociologist, pioneered and explicitly linked the concept of memory to a collective entity, which he refers to as a group or society.⁶⁷ He approaches memory from a third-person perspective and applies sociological frameworks to analyze it, drawing inspiration from the work of Emile Durkheim.⁶⁸ In 1925, Halbwachs coined the term “*mémoire collective*” in his book *Les Cadres sociaux de la mémoire*. The important aspects of Halbwachs’s assumption are his identification of those “who remember” and “how” that process happens over time. Halbwachs argues that a person’s memory develops and is shaped by the social group they are part of.⁶⁹ He states that all memory is dependent on the interactions among various social groupings. These groups include families, socioeconomic classes, and religious communities. The way one remembers past experiences and what exactly they remember depends on how socially connected they are to the other members of their group.⁷⁰ In short, Halbwachs argues

⁶⁷ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 37–189.

⁶⁸ Paul Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2004), 120.

⁶⁹ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 97.

⁷⁰ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 52.

that groups collectively rebuild their past experiences. Therefore, while individuals may have

their own perspective on this group reconstruction, they do not possess an independent memory of the past.⁷¹

Collective memory is interconnected with, yet somewhat different from, individual memory, as it is bound to transmit information from one generation to another, surpassing the individual's memory. Thus, it is meant to prevent selective forgetting, collective silence, or simply forgetting about any event that is associated with the concept of memory.⁷² The term "silence" is as a result complex. Certain aspects of any given experience or narrative are inevitably forgotten as we observe, classify, and then remember others. Studies of silences, omissions, and amnesia have their own subfield within collective memory studies.⁷³ Trauma, individual, and collective conflicts sometimes break the silence and express memories. At the same time, silence can be so enduring that it effaces memory and induces forgetting. Sometimes, the story takes on a new and enriched form after staying for too long in darkness.⁷⁴

Halbwachs highlights the significance of the societal framework in shaping collective memory and the act of forgetting within the realm of history. In doing so, he discusses the connection between memory and history. According to his argument, social dynamics and challenges have an impact on memory. Memory changes constantly as new social or political pressures arise in society. On the other hand, political or social forces have no influence over history. His argument suggests that forgetting can be a result of collective memory, sometimes

⁷¹ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 67.

⁷² Yair Auron, *The Pain of Knowledge: Holocaust and Genocide Issues in Education* (New York: Routledge, 2005),

⁷³ 3. Lisa-Jo K. van den Scott, "Collective Memory," in *The Routledge International Handbook of Interactionism*, ed. Dirk vom Lehn, Natalia Ruiz-Junco, Will Gibson (London: Routledge, 2021), 270.

⁷⁴ Luisa Passerini, *Memory and Utopia: The Primacy of Inter-Subjectivity* (New York: Routledge, 2007), 16.

intentionally, but not of history. He further contends that contemporary societies are unable to generate collective memories as a result of the extensive documentation and historical investigation available to them. The way the past is written is significantly different from lived experiences. It is also schematic and dissimilar to how people remember their past experiences.⁷⁵

Halbwachs frequently discusses the influence of collective frames in shaping collective memory, emphasizing their role in the selection, reconstruction, and distortion of memories.⁷⁶ These frames include language, time, space, and experience. Forgetting occurs when our attention is unable to concentrate on particular memories or is diverted elsewhere as these frames evolve throughout time.⁷⁷ The collective frames of memories are not composed of individual memories or available structures. Instead, they are employed to (re)construct a historical narrative that fits into the dominant ideologies of contemporary society.⁷⁸ Hegemony sometimes ignores memories that create differences among individuals and groups, manipulating them to preserve consistency in every phase of history. This is done to preserve agreement with the changing conditions of balance, ensuring that memory remains relevant.⁷⁹ The concept of hegemony involves the acceptance of the dominant group's interests as the norm. This acceptance results in the establishment of a specific narrative as a universal truth, marginalizing alternative perspectives or certain social groups. Thus, hegemony effectively creates a dominant reality that most individuals within a social group adopt, while undermining other viewpoints.⁸⁰ As a result, certain aspects of history are silenced or distorted.

⁷⁵ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 118.

⁷⁶ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 382.

⁷⁷ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 368.

⁷⁸ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 22–23.

⁷⁹ Halbwachs, *On Collective Memory*, 382.

⁸⁰ Berthold Molden, "Resistant pasts versus mnemonic hegemony: On the power relations of collective memory," *Memory Studies* 9, no. 2 (2016): 126.

Collective forgetting, a kind of silencing, is a result of collective consciousness or deliberate acts. Any time the past is remembered, certain details are always emphasized while others are overlooked or forgotten. Even interpreting historical events and forgetting parts of them is not necessarily always an intentional act. According to Michael Schudson, "[m]emory is distortion since memory is invariably and inevitably selective. A way of seeing is a way of not seeing, a way of remembering is a way of forgetting too."⁸¹ In this sense, memory and forgetting go hand in hand. The ability to remember a particular event frequently depends on the capacity to suppress something else. The continued existence of these moments of exclusion can have detrimental effects and frequently serve as deliberate efforts to silence specific aspects of history in order to represent others in a more effective manner, typically benefiting those who hold positions of power. Individuals in positions of power exercise the act of narrating certain memories while remaining silent about others as a means of defining the limits of what can and cannot be discussed regarding the past.⁸²

The continuous absence of any reference to a given subject in group communications enhances the act of forgetting. Time itself may increase the likelihood of encountering silence as witnesses or victims pass away or get older. In other cases, silence does not result from forgetting, but rather, from the desire of the individuals involved to keep a certain topic private or to avoid that which they find uncomfortable to discuss.⁸³ When people are silent, denial may play a role that includes fear, embarrassment, and trying to fit into the dominant culture through their silence.⁸⁴

⁸¹ Michael Schudson, "Dynamics of distortion in collective memory," in *Memory distortion: How minds, brains, and societies reconstruct the past*, ed. Daniel Schacter (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1995): 348. ⁸²

Vinitzky-Seroussi, and Teeger, "Unpacking the Unspoken," 1107.

⁸³ Lisa-Jo K. van den Scott, "Collective Memory," 271.

⁸⁴ Lisa-Jo K. van den Scott, "Collective Memory," 271.

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Historical Narratives, Power Dynamics and Reconstruction of the Past

The process of reconstructing the past may intentionally or unintentionally erase certain aspects of history and groups of people, leading to potential silences in the historical narrative.⁸⁵

Silencing certain groups of people can result in the misrepresentation of the past, creating a vague understanding of a particular historical event.⁸⁶ This silence can be found in sources, archives, academic histories, and, more generally, in the ways that societies remember the past, narrate stories, and assign historical meaning.⁸⁷ Silences within history and memory are produced and reaffirmed at many sites: through the selection of historical sources, the creation of archives, and the repositories of historical records.⁸⁸ The official process of collecting historical sources accidentally removes some parts whereas some of the recorded past is intentionally erased. By doing so, history sometimes produces only a partial record of the past; however, it becomes the final product backed by the official power of the state and is memorialized. The official history must be questioned in order to un-silence the unnarrated ones.⁸⁹

History is selectively portrayed, with some events compromised while others are highlighted for specific purposes, like creating a coherent picture, making a strong argument, or telling an effective story. Trouillot investigates how power dynamics affect the production of history. Power dynamics determine which historical actors and narratives are highlighted or silenced. He argues that inequalities among individuals result in unequal historical power, shaping what is included and excluded in historical records. In short, while some information is

⁸⁵ Vinitzky-Seroussi, and Teeger, "Unpacking the Unspoken," 1107.

⁸⁶ Vinitzky-Seroussi and Teeger, "Unpacking the Unspoken," 1104.

⁸⁷ James Miles, "Historical silences and the enduring power of counter storytelling," *Curriculum Inquiry* 49, no 3 (2019): 253.

⁸⁸ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 28–35.

⁸⁹ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 28–54.

recorded as fact, other elements are inevitably left out of historical records.⁹⁰ Trouillot states, "[s]ilences are inherent in history because any single event enters history with some of its constituting parts missing. Something is always left out while something else is recorded."⁹¹

Trouillot's concept of historical silence goes beyond the idea that history is shaped by the victors. According to him, silence is not only the outcome of how Western authorities produce historical narratives that reinstate the dominance of certain powerful groups. Power also plays a significant role in shaping the stories we recount about the past across various contexts and periods. Power contributes to the production and interpretation of events or stories, influencing their understanding and formation even before they are articulated.⁹² Therefore, even in a purely scientific understanding of history, the perspectives and interests of historians remain important. Trouillot further posits that "[i]n history, power begins at the source."⁹³ Sources and facts are not random, rather they are important in the production of narratives. The formation of sources and facts involves the omission of certain details, leading to silence in the narrative. Similarly, the production of traces, such as physical markers or historical artifacts, dead bodies, censuses, monuments, diaries, and political boundaries, shapes the significance of historical narratives.⁹⁴

Both the processes of generating sources and creating archives are important in shaping historical narratives. However, the power involved in both processes may vary.⁹⁵ For instance, the process of creating archives involves the deliberate selection of producers, evidence, themes, and procedures. As a result, specific elements may be excluded or ranked differently, ensuring

⁹⁰ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 48

⁹¹ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 49.

⁹² Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 28–29.

⁹³ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 29.

⁹⁴ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 29.

⁹⁵ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 52.

thorough selection and preservation.⁹⁶ Trouillot refers to archives as institutions that systematically arrange and preserve factual information and sources, which are essential for the creation of historical statements.⁹⁷ Archives are active spaces where information is processed to make it understandable in a historical context. They organize both the content and structure of historical narratives. They serve as intermediaries between sociohistorical processes and narratives, imposing limitations on the scope of debate and conveying a sense of authority. They establish guidelines for credibility and interdependence, and assist in choosing significant narratives, ensuring the authenticity of the data they gather.⁹⁸

Another phase of silencing involves retrieving factual information from historical narratives. Silence persists in fact retrieval even when ‘facts’ are extensively documented in archives. It implies that despite having a comprehensive account of events, the process of remembering and retelling history is not a simple or direct procedure. The process of retrieving information involves the complex interaction between information that is visible and information that is omitted. The narrative that emerges from historical accounts may vary in terms of which events are emphasized, how frequently they are mentioned, and the perceived importance or accuracy of those events. This unevenness in the retrieval and recollection of historical facts highlights the subjective nature of historical storytelling and interpretation that facilitate silence.⁹⁹

⁹⁶ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 53.

⁹⁷ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 52.

⁹⁸ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 52.

⁹⁹ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 53.

Survivors often carry the weight of history.¹⁰⁰ The significance of history also lies in its inherent purpose. Historical representations through books, commercial exhibits, or public commemorations, should not be seen solely as a means of transmitting knowledge. A connection to that information must be established. Moreover, not every relationship will suffice. Authenticity is crucial to avoid creating fraudulent or morally objectionable observations.¹⁰¹ It is necessary to address the injustices inflicted upon past generations as they have a direct impact on future generations of victims. Further, the emphasis on historical events frequently distracts us from the current injustices that are a result of the groundwork laid by prior generations.¹⁰²

Oral History and Silence

Oral history is a methodology that goes beyond simply gathering ‘facts’ about experience. It also offers profound personal insights into how individuals interpret the past.¹⁰³ Contemporary oral historians have gained the ability to establish questions that may not have been previously considered. Through this approach, individuals can effectively discover hidden memories and understand experiences that were previously suppressed or overlooked.¹⁰⁴ Oral historians interpret periods of silence through the practice of attentive listening. They exhibit an ability to attentively listen to individuals in order to gather knowledge about their cultures that has not yet been adequately examined or studied. Women’s studies and subaltern studies emerged from this

¹⁰⁰ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 149.

¹⁰¹ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 149.

¹⁰² Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 150.

¹⁰³ Alessandro Portelli, *The Death of Luigi Trastulli, and other stories: form and meaning in oral history* (NY: State University of New York Press, 1991), 50.

¹⁰⁴ Alistair Thompson, "Fifty Years On: An International Perspective on Oral History," *The Journal of American History* 85, no. 2 (1998): 584.

same impulse, as their aim is to facilitate new ways of listening to voices that had not previously been heard.¹⁰⁵

Oral history studies frequently exhibit information gaps, which may result in moments of silence. Verne Harris, an archivist from South Africa, highlights the importance of performing gathered oral histories aloud by emphasizing its ability to enhance the text with additional meaning. This process establishes a fluid connection between the text and its social context, physical surroundings, geographical features, and cultural artifacts. He further emphasizes the risks of documenting oral histories, as this transition process may interrupt the natural flow and setting of the stories, ultimately creating a gap between the speaker and their words. Additionally, it is important to note that pauses and sighs can have significant meaning and should be taken into consideration during the process of recording interviews. It is possible that the attempt to give individuals who are silenced a voice can ironically end up contributing to the continuation of their voicelessness.¹⁰⁶ Oral narrative can tell us how everyday identities become reformulated in various ways. In relation to violence, they provide some indications of how violent moments are enfolded into the everyday lives of people. Oral testimonies are illuminating in a way that they not only tell us what happened, but also how and why it happened, centralizing the meaning

of events.¹⁰⁷

¹⁰⁵ Passerini, *Memory and Utopia*, 28.

¹⁰⁶ Verne Harris, "Claiming Less, Delivering More: a critique of positivist formulations on archives in South Africa," *Archivaria* 44 (Fall 1997): 139.

¹⁰⁷ Veena Das, "The Act of Witnessing: Violence, Poisonous knowledge, and Subjectivity," in *Violence and Subjectivity*, ed. Veena Das, Arthur Kleinman, Mamphela Ramphele, and Pamela Reynolds (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2000): 205–25.

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Women's recollections are often interested in the contexts of daily life in which they attempt to make and maintain their homes and relationships.¹⁰⁸ Oral accounts also alert us to how violence and violations are not only contained in time, but have effects that far exceed the original moment of violence. One example could be the African Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) in which women adopted many strategies for remembering past violence. Their stories bear witness to their lived experiences as well as the formulation of new forms of agency in unexpected places under the daily conditions of horror. TRC accounts reflect how apartheid violence entered the emotional and conceptual frameworks of relationships between mothers and sons, between wives and husbands, and between other women in their everyday lives. Some of these include the impact governmental terror has on changing how people and communities interact with one another. In short, it bears witness to the texture of the fragmented lived experiences of the self, family, and community.¹⁰⁹

Conducting research on oral history and interacting with people can also present a few challenges. One of them is associated with the concept of distorted memories. Human memory is prone to error, and memories of the past can change through time. In the early 1970s, oral history

research faced the criticism that memory alters through physical degradation and nostalgia in old age, by the personal bias of both the interviewer and the interviewee, and by the effect of collective and retrospective memories of the past.¹¹⁰ Patrick O'Farrell argued that such distortion will not lead us into history but into myth.¹¹¹

¹⁰⁸ Nthabiseng Motsemme, "The Mute Always Speak: On Women's Silences at the Truth and Reconciliation Commission," *Current Sociology* 52, no. 5 (June 29, 2016): 909.

¹⁰⁹ Motsemme, "The Mute Always Speak," 909–910.

¹¹⁰ Thomson, "Fifty Years On," 584.

¹¹¹ Patrick O'Farrell, "Oral History: Facts and Fiction," *Oral History Association of Australia Journal*, no. 5 (1982–1983), 3–9.

When survivors of traumatic events share their stories, they describe feelings of helplessness and powerlessness. Their speech also conveys the sense of inferiority and embarrassment they are experiencing. In her research on Holocaust testimony and absence, Naomi Rosh White offers supporting arguments for such expression. She argues that in speech grief, anguish, shame, or joy may all be represented through silence. This idea of expressions, that is, affective or emotional expression as a form of communication, must be considered in the study of historical silence.¹¹²

In the political sphere of women's lives, silence matters. Choosing to remain silent in the face of those who seek to undermine or silence them can be a powerful political statement in itself. Through maintaining silence, individuals can create a sense of uncertainty and confusion among their opponents, making it challenging for them to formulate a response. This strategy is especially valuable for marginalized groups, such as women, who have historically faced oppression and powerlessness.¹¹³

Silence can also manifest negatively in various ways. Political repression and the suffocating silence of sexual violations are two examples of how silence negatively manifests. Coercion, physical violence, and emotional abuse are all used in these methods of silence. Silence can occasionally be used as a defense mechanism to safeguard others, maintain secrecy, or express reluctance to discuss specific events. Sexual harassment victims who choose to remain silent as a form of self-defense by avoiding talking about upsetting experiences, facilitate

¹¹² Naomi Rosh White, "Marking Absences: Holocaust Testimony and History," *The Oral History Association of Australia Journal*, no. 16 (1994): 12–18. <https://search.informit.org/doi/10.3316/informit.630758638456473>. ¹¹³ Rodney G.S. Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid: Power, Archival Silences, and Power in Silence," *Archivaria* 61 (September 2006): 230.

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silence.¹¹⁴ It is what Rosh White refers to as a survival tactic by individuals whose agency is being destroyed and called into doubt, as in the instance of apartheid.¹¹⁵

Violence in the Archive

Archives are spaces of power. Archival power is represented through acts of inclusion and exclusion. Through inclusion, archives highlight historical narratives or records created by certain groups. Such highlights give power to those voices that are heard. But inclusion is only one of many components of archival power. Through the fundamental aspect of exclusion, the archive carries distortions, omissions, erasures, and silences of stories that are not told or preserved.¹¹⁶

In society, dominant groups exercise power and establish an unequal relationship with subordinate groups, by displaying their influence.¹¹⁷ Power is distributed unevenly among groups

in society that include specific racial, ethnic, and religious communities, the affluent, and the educated, and can be defined by dominant gender and heterosexism. These dominant groups possess the power to generate historical records and shape them by exerting control over resources, such as information. They determine the content and structure of the archive by selecting which information will be archived.¹¹⁸ Through their continuous statements and funding for research, powerful groups subjugate individuals on the periphery who hold different views.

This kind of silencing prevents particular groups from expressing their opinions or

¹¹⁴ Portelli, *The Death of Luigi Trastulli*, 53.

¹¹⁵ White, "Marking Absences," 14.

¹¹⁶ Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid," 216.

¹¹⁷ Michel Foucault, "The Confessions of the Flesh," in *Power/Knowledge: Selected Interviews and Other Writings, 1972–1977*, ed. Colin Gordon (New York, Pantheon, 1980): 201.

¹¹⁸ Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid," 217.

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making remarks. Miriam Meyerhoff refers to it as "simple and perfect" silence, as the powerful control marginalized groups views through easy but effective tactics like censorship or threats.¹¹⁹

Archival silences occur when the materials of certain groups who are being marginalized by powerful groups are actively denied entry. If some of them speak, their speech or statements are not recognized and are denied a place in the archive due to a lack of power.¹²⁰ Jacques Derrida, a prominent French philosopher, goes a step further and argues that the archive is a place of violence; that is, state power is reflected in archival decisions and archival records that go through extremely selective processes before finding a place in the archive. State power favours dominant groups. Marginalized groups in a society remain marginalized in archives because of this extremely selective procedure.¹²¹

For instance, prominent African American studies and critical theory scholar Saidiya Hartman expands the concept of archival violence, especially focusing on the ways in which the representation and documentation of Black lives are manipulated and marginalized. Hartman argues that traditional archival practices actively contribute to the suppression of marginalized people's voices, experiences, and agency, hence sustaining violence against them. Hartman's viewpoint on archival violence emphasizes the problematic nature of historical records as sources of trauma and exploitation. She argues that archives often preserve materials that actively contribute to the continuation of violence, especially in the context of slavery, colonialism, and other oppressive institutions. Instead of serving as impartial archives of history,

¹¹⁹ Miriam Meyerhoff, "Doing and Saying: Some Words on Women's Silence," in *Language and Woman's Place: Text and Commentaries, revised and expanded edition*, ed. Mary Bucholtz (Toronto: Oxford University Press, 2004): 209.

¹²⁰ Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid," 218.

¹²¹ Jacques Derrida and Eric Prenowitz, "Archive Fever: A Freudian Impression," *Diacritics* 25, no. 2 (1995): 7.

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these records are perceived as actively perpetuating harm by presenting the narratives of marginalized groups through the perspective of their oppressors.¹²²

Furthermore, traditional archives overlook the intricate details of everyday experiences, emotions, and relationships inside Black communities, which reduces them to impersonal facts or oversimplified portrayals. Hartman writes:

[w]e stumble upon her (Venus) in exorbitant circumstances that yield no picture of the everyday life, no pathway to her thoughts, no glimpse of the vulnerability of her face or of what looking at such a face might demand. We only know what can be extrapolated from an analysis of the ledger or borrowed from the world of her captors and masters and applied to her.¹²³

This omission not only affects historical understandings but also reinforces structural inequalities

by repeating harmful stereotypes and silencing dissenting voices that resist dominant narratives.

Archival violence takes place when some groups are prioritized and included in the archive reflecting the state's power while others are excluded and actively silenced. Archivists must make constant choices when selecting appropriate archival materials. Sometimes such decisions are made by the archivist in an unconscious way depending on factors such as limited resources, a lack of understanding, and budget constraints. Authoritative decisions like actively excluding certain voices and their records have a major impact on the archival structure and complicate the societal memory of the state.¹²⁴ At the same time, the idea of a complete archive that can fully preserve the memory of a culture is deemed impossible since memory differs from person to person. The whole spectrum of stories appears to be unattainable, even with archivists' efforts to include multiple voices in archives.¹²⁵ Gaps in the archive limit the group's ability to

¹²² Saidiya Hartman, "Venus in two acts," *Small Axe: A Caribbean Journal of Criticism* 12, no. 2 (2008): 1–3.

¹²³ Hartman, "Venus in two acts," 2.

¹²⁴ Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid," 219.

¹²⁵ Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid," 220–221.

construct and preserve its narrative and history. Lack of access to archives disrupts retaining information over time, which makes it challenging to form a strong sense of collective identity.¹²⁶

Jacques Derrida argues that the concept of memory inherently includes the element of forgetting. He writes "... the archive—the good one—produces memory but produces forgetting at the same time ... [T]he trace is at the same time the memory, the archive, and the erasure, the repression, the forgetting of what is supposed to be kept safe."¹²⁷ Similarly, silence and speech are connected. Silence is an essential component of the existence of speech, since its absence

would result in chaotic noise without any structure. In the same way, silence depends on words in order to provide them with meaning and context; without which, silence would be irrelevant. The unsaid determines and defines what is being said and what is missing. Rodney Carter names this intriguing idea that can be found in the archive an absent-presence. It describes a situation in which what is present is determined by what is absent. The preserved record in the archive determines the story and demonstrates the absent piece of history.¹²⁸

Archival silence impacts history, memory, and identity by allowing powerful groups to manipulate historical understanding. This process, referred to as preserving a “sliver of a sliver of a sliver” of the documentary universe, results in a void in collective memory.¹²⁹ In Pierre Nora’s words, modern memory is archival.¹³⁰ M.T. Clanchy argues that archivists are the

¹²⁶ Carter, “Of Things Said and Unsaid,” 221.

¹²⁷ Jacques Derrida, “Archive Fever in South Africa,” in *Refiguring the Archive*, ed. David Philip (Cape Town, 2002): 54.

¹²⁸ Carter, “Of Things Said and Unsaid,” 223.

¹²⁹ Harris, “Claiming Less, Delivering More,” 97.

¹³⁰ Pierre Nora, “Between Memory and History,” 13.

“keepers of a society’s collective record of the past.”¹³¹ The collective memory of any event is shaped by the archivist, his or her decisions, and the form of the archives. Impaired human memory affects our ability to remember the past and recollect ideas and thoughts.¹³² Similarly, when the archive is impaired by silence, the collective memory of a nation is significantly impacted. Only powerful groups can counter such silences. Marginalized groups lose their history as the stories they tell disappear in the archival process and preservation.¹³³ According to Susan Gal, silence is traditionally deplored as “those who are denied speech cannot make their experience known and thus cannot influence the course of their lives or of history.”¹³⁴ As a result,

the archive is compromised.

Sexual Violence in War and Memory

Conflict-related sexual violence has consistently been an ongoing problem throughout history, particularly during times of war. It is often disregarded as a secondary consequence of more significant acts of violence. The suffering of women and girls who endure sexual violence has been a persistent occurrence throughout different historical periods in conjunction with warfare. These atrocities have been committed in a methodical manner, regardless of whether men were involved in offensive or defensive warfare.¹³⁵ Gender-specific aspects of memory, especially in times of war and brutality, are often overlooked in traditional narratives. Whether

¹³¹ M.T. Clanchy, "'Tenacious Letters': Archives and Memory in the Middle Ages," *Archivaria* 11 (Winter 1980–81), 116.

¹³² Barbara L. Craig, "Selected Themes in the Literature on Memory and Their Pertinence to Archives," *American Archivist* 65, no. 2 (Fall/Winter 2002): 282.

¹³³ Carter, "Of Things Said and Unsaid," 220.

¹³⁴ Susan Gal, "Between Speech and Silence: The Problematics of Research on Language and Gender," in *The Women and Language Debate: A Sourcebook*, ed. Camille Roman, Suzanne Juhasz, and Cristanne Miller (New Brunswick, NJ, 1994): 407.

¹³⁵ Olivera Simic, *Silenced Victims of Wartime Sexual Violence* (London: Routledge, 2018), 13.

women are the perpetrators or the victims of genocide, the history, memory, and ideologies surrounding these events are frequently seen as male property.¹³⁶

In the last twenty years, researchers in the field of genocide studies have integrated the perspectives of women and gendered viewpoints into their examination of the Holocaust and more recent events of war and conflict.¹³⁷ For instance, the Second World War narratives frequently portray nations as either victorious or as victims, although the existence of atrocities

committed during the war and subsequent efforts to hide them pose a challenge to these assertions. The memory of conflicts is crucial for a nation's identity, and the public recognition of sexual violence can impact the present-day identities of the peoples of Russia, Germany, or France.¹³⁸ In what follows, I describe instances of wartime sexual violence in two historical moments: during the Second World War and comfort women's victimization before and during the Second World War.

The Second World War: The Second World War (1939–1945) witnessed the perpetration of various atrocities by armed forces, with the Holocaust standing out as a widely recognized historical event. During this period of intense struggle, Jews were specifically targeted and systematically killed due to their Jewish identity. The memory of sexual violence committed by Germans and Russians during the Second World War is often overlooked or forgotten, making it less well publicized. If well publicized in the media, it could threaten the

¹³⁶ Elissa Bemporad and Joyce W. Warren, *Memory, Body, and Power: Women and the Study of Genocide* (Indiana: Indiana University Press, 2018), 5.

¹³⁷ Scholars whose works focus on the women and gendered viewpoints in war and genocide are: Amy E. Randall, ed., *Genocide and Gender in the Twentieth Century: A Comparative Study* (London: Bloomsbury Academic, 2015); Adam Jones, ed., *Gendercide and Genocide* (Nashville, TN: Vanderbilt University Press, 2004); Samuel Totten, ed., *Plight and Fate of Women During and Following Genocide* (New Brunswick, NJ: Transaction Publishers, 2009); and Andrea Smith, *Conquest: Sexual Violence and American Indian Genocide* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2015).

¹³⁸ Sonia Tiemann, "Rape In World War II Memory" (Honors Thesis, Union College - Schenectady, NY, 2014), 77.

dominant wartime narrative of perpetrators and provide recognition to silenced victims.¹³⁹ In order to make women visible and a part of war memory, it is imperative to recognize and acknowledge the prevalence of sexual violence during war. The public narrative of a nation often contradicts the actual realities on the ground. For instance, when referring to Russia's "Great Patriotic War," the accounts generally exclude mention of sexual violence as one of the atrocities perpetrated by Germany. Germany has a motive to deny these heinous acts because of its

wartime dominance over the conquered territories and subsequent memories of the Holocaust. Therefore, the memory of the Jewish Holocaust is predominantly influenced by men, with Jewish women often being overlooked and not specifically acknowledged for their experiences of sexual violence within the broader Jewish narrative of suffering.¹⁴⁰

Sexual assault was widespread in Germany and Europe during the Second World War, particularly among Jewish women who were victims of extreme brutality. However, survivors refrained from publicly addressing or documenting their traumatic experience.¹⁴¹ According to Zoe Waxman, women who suffered sexual abuse during the Holocaust have difficulty sharing their stories in a culture that rejects the existence of sexual violence during the Holocaust.¹⁴² It was prohibited for Germans to “comingle” with the Jewish race. This prohibition coupled with the stigma attached to Jewish women being sexually abused by German soldiers, created a culture of silence and denial around these atrocities. As a result, both Jewish women and German soldiers wanted to forget the occurrence of sexual violence.¹⁴³

¹³⁹ Tiemann, “Rape In World War II Memory,” 33.

¹⁴⁰ Zoe Waxman, “Rape and Sexual Abuse in Hiding,” in *Sexual Violence Against Jewish Women During the Holocaust*, ed. Sonja M. Hedgepeth and Rochelle G. Saidel (Waltham Brandeis University Press, 2010), 129.

¹⁴¹ Waxman, “Rape and Sexual Abuse in Hiding,” 124.

¹⁴² Waxman, “Rape and Sexual Abuse in Hiding,” 128.

¹⁴³ Tiemann, “Rape In World War II Memory,” 37.

The Holocaust permanently stays in the minds of survivors, manifesting as constant reminders in their everyday existence. While both men and women hold memories of their traumatic experiences, women face challenges in effectively sharing their narratives. Men often struggle to understand the widespread concern regarding the sexual violence that women constantly endure, leading women to feel excluded from the narrative. This, in turn, limits

women's ability to properly convey their lived experience.¹⁴⁴

Following the Second World War, there has been a growing appreciation for the courage displayed by the Red Army.¹⁴⁵ However, this appreciation often fails to acknowledge the grave acts of violence perpetrated against the girls and women of Berlin. This historical paradox is characterized by the victimization of German girls and women, many of whom were supporters of the Nazi regime, by Red Army soldiers who had liberated Hitler's concentration camps.¹⁴⁶ Further, mass sexual assault in Berlin strengthened the Russian collaboration by dehumanizing and weakening the status of other women, dividing Russian men from all German women, and deepening the bonds between the Russian men. These acts of violence were driven by a desire for masculine dominance and conquest, with sexual assault being a tool to assert power and self esteem among the perpetrators. The emotional and physical trauma endured by the victims contrasts sharply with the reinforcement of masculine identity among the soldiers.¹⁴⁷

The Red Army subjected several German women to sexual violence as a retaliatory measure for the harm inflicted upon Russian women by Germans during the Second World War.

¹⁴⁴ Tiemann, "Rape In World War II Memory," 48.

¹⁴⁵ The Red Army was the official name of the armed forces of Soviet Russia and later the Soviet Union. ¹⁴⁶ James Messerschmidt, "The forgotten victims of World War II: masculinities and rape in Berlin, 1945," *Violence Against Women* 12, no. 7 (July 2006): 706.

¹⁴⁷ Messerschmidt, "The forgotten victims of World War II," 708.

This sexual violence was particularly prevalent in Berlin, leading to consequences such as unwanted pregnancies and the legalization of abortions for women who were assaulted. Due to the widespread belief that they were superior, Germans did not want mixed-race children.¹⁴⁸ The patriarchal culture in Germany during this time contributed to the shame associated with sexual

violence, as men felt humiliated by the idea of their wives being assaulted. This shame further suppressed men's ability to address their wives' trauma, leading to a culture of silence among German women about their wartime experiences.¹⁴⁹ Both German and Russian soldiers were reluctant to acknowledge the involvement of their troops in sexual violence against German women, creating a cycle of denial and silence surrounding these atrocities.¹⁵⁰

The Comfort Women: The existence of “comfort women” in Japan has been widely reported since the 1990s, despite the Japanese government's constant denial of any involvement in the violence. Their existence poses a serious challenge to the victimization narrative, which is inconsistent with the systematic and strategic nature of the issue and Japan's version of events during the war.¹⁵¹ The worldwide dispute around this subject developed in the 1990s when the existence of “comfort women” was revealed, leading to a subsequent public outrage against the Japanese government's efforts to hide these crimes following the war.¹⁵² The Japanese Imperial Army used “comfort women,” primarily of Korean descent, as forced sexual slaves. Japan had already established influence over Korea. While women from various Asian countries were recruited, the majority were Korean due to Japan's pre-existing perception of Koreans as inferior.

¹⁴⁸ Atina Grossmann, “Question of Silence,” in *Women and War in the Twentieth Century* (London: Routledge, 1999), 55.

¹⁴⁹ Grossmann, “Question of Silence,” 61.

¹⁵⁰ Grossmann, “Question of Silence,” 62.

¹⁵¹ Tiemann, “Rape In World War II Memory,” 6.

¹⁵² Yuki Tanaka, *Hidden Horrors: Japanese War Crimes in World War II* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1996), 79.

The term “comfort women” stemmed from the belief that they would provide care and happiness to soldiers, unaware that their duties included sexual services.¹⁵³

In traditional patriarchal Confucian society, the innocence of Korean women was highly valued and preserved until their marriage. However, during the Japanese occupation of Korea from 1910 to 1945, the Japanese Imperial Army forcibly took unmarried Korean women, believing in their own superiority. They justified their actions by advocating for the preservation of purity and chastity to prevent the spread of venereal diseases. This led to the coercion of Korean women into becoming “comfort women” because of racial prejudice stemming from their perceived inferiority.¹⁵⁴ The exact number of women who have been exploited is hard to determine because of missing or distorted documentation. The estimates vary between 80,000 and 100,000, according to the Japanese military plan, which stipulated the need for 20,000 comfort women for every 700,000 soldiers.¹⁵⁵

The controversy surrounding Japan’s actions during the Second World War has been fueled by the testimonies of surviving comfort women who have bravely spoken out about the practice of sex slavery. Despite these allegations, the Japanese government vehemently denies any involvement, choosing instead to focus on the suffering endured by the Japanese people during the war. This stance has led to tensions and conflicts with neighbouring countries as Japan continued to assert its own victimhood in the Second World War.¹⁵⁶

¹⁵³ Yoshimi Yoshiaki, *Comfort Women: Sexual Slavery in the Japanese Military During World War II*, trans. Suzanne O’Brien (New York: Columbia University Press, 1995), 106.

¹⁵⁴ Yuki Tanaka, *Japan’s Comfort Women* (London: Routledge, 2003), 31.

¹⁵⁵ Tanaka, *Hidden Horrors*, 99.

¹⁵⁶ Tiemann, “Rape In World War II Memory,” 78.

victimization of Japanese women in comfort stations during wartime. She draws attention to the widespread failure of historians to acknowledge this fact and points out that scholars either failed to include Japanese women in descriptions of individuals who were recruited or suggested that their numbers were insignificant. Norma argues that some historians even actively deny that Japanese women were targeted for trafficking. This exclusion of Japanese women from the narrative of comfort women has led to their marginalization in the pursuit of justice for these victims.¹⁵⁷

Silence as a form of Symbolic and Structural Violence

The relationship between wartime and postwar violence is seen as interrelated, where injustices resulting from regimes of power are reflected in micro level life processes and structural inequalities in access to basic rights and social services. These disparities contribute to both tangible and symbolic forms of violence, including social marginalization, degradation, rejection, self-devaluation, and abuse. These disparities influence individuals' behaviour and comprehension of the world, underscoring the importance of acknowledging the relationship between complex operation of violence and dynamics of violence.¹⁵⁸

Symbolic violence is a strategy used to silence the controlled and practice discrete domination.

It is frequently unnoticeable and hidden. French Sociologist Pierre Bourdieu established the concept of “symbolic violence,” which describes how symbolic dominance— rather than physical force—maintains social hierarchies and inequalities. It is mostly expressed

¹⁵⁷ Caroline Norma, *Japanese Comfort Women and Sexual Slavery During the China and Pacific Wars* (Bloomsbury, 2016), 36–49.

¹⁵⁸ Cecilia Menjivar, *Enduring Violence: Ladina Women's Lives in Guatemala* (California: The University of California Press, 2011): 7–8.

through symbolic means of communication, cognition, recognition, or even emotion, which have an impact on Bourdieu's theory of power and domination.¹⁵⁹

Symbolic violence encompasses the dynamics of power and relationships that are not built on physical force or bodily harm. These fundamental forms of control arise from interpersonal interactions rather than institutional mechanisms. It is widespread in social contexts beyond the family, as well as within the family, especially in establishing a relationship of dominance over women.¹⁶⁰ In this instance, symbolic power needs to be understood from within and through the specific relationship between the people who exercise it and the people who submit to it. The power of words and ideas lies in their legitimacy and the credibility of those who express them, as they are generated and perpetuated within the realm of belief.¹⁶¹

People in society frequently fail to acknowledge the social causes of suffering, which exacerbates the problem and maintains symbolic hierarchies of power.¹⁶² The privileged classes follow the regulations of their privilege-granting system and are restricted within it. The perpetuation of these hierarchies and systems of dominance occurs when those in power and those who are subjugated view these systems as valid, causing them to behave in a manner that serves their own advantages within the system.¹⁶³

Systemic inequalities in everyday lives and interpersonal attitudes are maintained and promoted by processes and mechanisms apparent in symbolic encounters, communication and

¹⁵⁹ Pierre Bourdieu, *Masculine domination*, trans. Richard Nice (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2001), 2. ¹⁶⁰ Beate Krais, "Gender and symbolic violence: female oppression in light of Pierre Bourdieu's theory of social practice," in *Bourdieu: Critical Perspectives*, ed. Craig Calhoun, Edward LiPuma, and Moishe Postone (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1993), 171.

¹⁶¹ Pierre Bourdieu, *Language and Symbolic Power* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2002), 170. ¹⁶² Daniel Schubert, "Suffering/Symbolic violence," in *Pierre Bourdieu: Key Concepts*, ed. Michael Grenfell (London: Routledge, 2013), 180.

¹⁶³ Schubert, "Suffering/Symbolic violence," 180.

behaviour. Power operates through individuals' lack of comprehension regarding the underlying significance of everyday behaviours, rituals, and practices. According to Bourdieu, any language that is able to capture people's attention is considered "authorized language" and legitimate.¹⁶⁴ In turn, this authorized language suppresses and silences other viewpoints in the narrative through misrecognition.

The misrecognition of causes along with blame for acts of violence highlights the prevalence of the victim-blaming narrative, which is not only socially endorsed but also acknowledged as a worldwide concern. For example, women may internalize when they give in to their abuser's requests in order to stop more violence from happening. The abuser wants to undermine the victim's agency and voice while highlighting their weaknesses. Consequently, the victim adopts the abuser's attitude, resulting in a loss of their own viewpoint when it comes to relationships. Victims frequently experience a sense of uncertainty and disbelief finding it challenging to express what happened to them.¹⁶⁵

Inequalities and injustices in society can be understood as a form of structural violence.

Structural violence is important because it identifies harm within societal structures that perpetuates inequality and hinders individuals from reaching their full potential. The concept was introduced and popularized by Norwegian Sociologist and "father of peace studies," Johan Galtung, who referred to structural violence as a silent form of violence.¹⁶⁶ In a culture that does not change, personal violence will be seen as wrong, but structural violence might be seen as

¹⁶⁴ Pierre Bourdieu, *Outline of a Theory of Practice* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1977), 170–71. ¹⁶⁵ Suruchi Thapar-Björkert, Lotta Samelius and Gurchathen Sanghera, "Exploring symbolic violence in the everyday: misrecognition, condescension, consent and complicity," *Feminist Review* 112, no. 1 (February 2016): 151.

¹⁶⁶ Johan Galtung, "Violence, Peace, and Peace Research," *Journal of Peace Research* 6, no. 3 (1969): 173.

normal, like breathing.¹⁶⁷ According to Galtung, structural violence is widespread and frequently upheld by people who might not even be conscious of their contribution to maintaining systemic injustices.¹⁶⁸

In his work, Galtung makes a distinction between structural and direct violence, emphasizing that the structural form of violence results in unequal opportunities for power and life and is intrinsic and not observable. As Galtung states, "violence is built into the structure and shows up as unequal power and consequently as unequal life chances."¹⁶⁹ Direct violence, on the other hand, arises from physical injury and is perpetrated by individuals. Structural violence stems from a gradual and ongoing process, and this is why it is silent in nature.¹⁷⁰ This differentiation underscores the intricate character of violence and its influence on individuals.¹⁷¹

Structural violence is commonly seen as the prevailing social order. However, it is encountered as injustice and violence at particular points where race, ethnicity, class, nationality, gender, and age interact. The power and coercion of dominant groups at the local, state, and international levels give rise to inequality, which takes the form of administrative, legal, and economic structures. These inequalities are justified by ideology, historical context, philosophical beliefs, and religious doctrines.¹⁷²

The violence that is perceived as injustice at intersections of race, class or gender is invisible to those who belong to the dominant culture because they have developed a tolerance

¹⁶⁷ Galtung, "Violence, Peace, and Peace Research," 173.

¹⁶⁸ Galtung, "Violence, Peace, and Peace Research," 174.

¹⁶⁹ Galtung, "Violence, Peace, and Peace Research," 171.

¹⁷⁰ Galtung, "Violence, Peace, and Peace Research," 171.

¹⁷¹ Menjivar, *Enduring Violence*, 30.

¹⁷² Lubna Nazir Chaudhury, "Reconstituting Selves in the Karachi Conflict: Mohajir Women Survivors and Structural Violence," *Cultural Dynamic* 16, no. 2/3 (2004): 260–61.

for inequality, which manifests itself in forms such as homelessness or poverty. Societal structural components frequently categorize specific populations as deserving of unfair treatment or reduced humanity, resulting in instances of violence. Illustrative instances encompass colonialism, racism, and socioeconomic disparity. In order to understand these structural inequalities, it is important to direct our attention towards their historical backgrounds and the specific components that give rise to these differences.¹⁷³ The interpretation of history for *biranganas* has been reshaped by this viewpoint, which is grounded in silence and instances of violence. Consequently, it encouraged me to focus my research on archival materials, as they encompass both historical context and present explanations, enabling me to gain a more comprehensive understanding of the experiences of *biranganas*.

Method and Data Collection

This thesis relies on archival and interdisciplinary methods. I draw on three categories of archival materials: historical photographs, newspaper cuttings, and published oral testimonies, to examine the techniques that were employed to silence the voices of survivors of sexual violence during the 1971 Liberation War. In this section, I will provide a brief overview of the selection criteria I used to determine which archives to consider and which types of documents to choose and analyze. I will also explain the methods I used when conducting archival research and analysis.

I utilized two primary criteria in the process of selecting archives for the purpose of this study. As previously mentioned in the introduction chapter, the availability of archives containing

¹⁷³ Joshua M Price, *Structural Violence: Hidden Brutality in the Lives of Women* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2012), 6. <https://doi.org/10.1353/book19307>.

records related to *biranganas* is limited in Bangladesh. The majority of archives primarily exhibit and preserve materials pertaining to the 1971 Liberation War in general. Most of the archives exhibit items representing male combatants, while the inclusion of materials concerning victims of sexual violence is hardly encountered within these extensive and widely accessed archives. Initially, I selected archives based on their activities and objectives, specifically focusing on the types of events they prioritize, as this increases the likelihood of obtaining relevant information from them. The objectives and activities of an organization also influence the nature of archival materials, the process of selecting them, and the methods used to preserve them. In order to be eligible for consideration in this study, archives were required to have materials pertaining to the victims of sexual violence during the 1971 Liberation War. Additionally, my attention was directed to the presence of supplementary literature to provide additional context and verification of the archival materials and their sources. Based on these two criteria, the following three archives were selected for this study: the Liberation War Museum archive and library at Agargaon, Dhaka, Bangladesh; the Ain-O-Salish Kendra library at Lalmatia, Dhaka, Bangladesh; and the digital archive Muktiyuddho e-archive¹⁷⁴ (Bangladesh Liberation War Archive).

Archival Field Work

Traditionally, the concept of an archive has evolved, now referring to authorized collections housed in a traditional setting.¹⁷⁵ Modern archives are characterized as repositories of

¹⁷⁴ Muktiyuddho e-Archive (Bangladesh Liberation War Archive - <https://www.liberationwarbangladesh.org/>) is a Digital Library working with the collection, maintenance and public viewing of the historical documents regarding the Bangladesh Liberation War, Genocide of Innocent Bengali People in 1971 and contemporary political events of Bangladesh.

¹⁷⁵ Lynée Lewis Gaillet, “(Per)Forming Archival Research Methodologies,” *College Composition and Communication* 64, no. 1 (September 2012): 39.

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primary sources that are utilized to construct narratives and generate knowledge, rather than being perceived solely as warehouses for locating pre-existing information.¹⁷⁶ Today, digital archives play a crucial role by generating an abundance of social data that was previously inaccessible to the general public. This concept broadens the understanding of archives by incorporating more democratic perspectives. Scholars contend that the archive is no longer confined to a physical space that houses a limited selection of objects. The concept of ‘the archive’ is characterized by its continuous evolution.¹⁷⁷ I have kept current scholarship on the multifaceted and evolving nature of the archive in mind in selecting archives for my study. I studied each archive to decide what types of information are stored there and how I can produce new knowledge using them in ways that will allow me to address my central research questions around the historical silencing of the *biranganas*.

In order to gain some background information regarding the Liberation War Museum and Ain-O-Shalish Kendra’s establishment and objectives, I read as much as I could about it before leaving for my research trip to Dhaka to look through the archives in person. Through an examination of manuscripts and publications from the Ain-O-Salish Kendra, I have formulated preliminary conclusions regarding their methods of selecting and maintaining records. My previous experience attending several seminars and workshops at these institutions as an undergraduate student also helped me determine the resources available there.

One key fact about archival research is building a positive and trusting relationship with the archivist before visiting it in-person. Establishing rapport with the archivist provides many social benefits for the researcher and determines the success of the research. Archivists are the

¹⁷⁶ Gaillet, “(Per)Forming Archival Research Methodologies,” 39.

¹⁷⁷ Gaillet, “(Per)Forming Archival Research Methodologies,” 54.

“gatekeeper” of the archive who are up-to-date on archival materials and can offer additional recommendations that might benefit the researcher with relevant materials.¹⁷⁸

The two archives I visited feature diverse categories of documents related to the 1971 Liberation War. I was unable to thoroughly examine each file and gather all the relevant documents. During my visit to the Liberation War Museum archive, I sought guidance from Rezina Begum, the head of research and library, who had the best understanding of the structure of the archive. She recommended that I explore Gallery 4 of the repository, which has various documents on the victims of 1971 sexual violence. During my visit to Ain-O-Salish Kendra, I sought guidance from Rakhee Zaman, who has been a part of this NGO for a long period. She supplied me with crucial information regarding their collection. Prior to visiting these archives in person, I established a positive relationship with both of them and gained confidence by maintaining regular communication via email. The third archive I have utilized is an internet based archive accessible to the general public. The website, <https://www.liberationwarbangladesh.org/> serves as a Digital Library that houses a collection of photographs, historical documents, books, and other important items related to the 1971 Liberation War.

I have collected three different types of materials from these three archives for my study. From the Liberation War Museum, I was able to collect historical photographs and published books with the oral testimonies of the sexual assault victims. Ain-O-Salish Kendra archives newspaper articles on *biranganas* from different decades. I was able to locate and collect newspaper cuttings and published books with the oral testimonies of the sexual assault victims

¹⁷⁸ Maureen Wangard, *Archival Research: Using Modern Techniques to Reveal the Past* (London: SAGE Publications Ltd: 2023), 12.

from this archive. Finally, the digital archive provides me with a rich source of additional historical photographs and newspaper articles that I did not find in any of the two archives in Dhaka. I am confident that I have an in-depth understanding of every archive I have selected for this study, but I also admit that, due to the volume of information stored there, there are a lot of fascinating items and materials I may have overlooked.

Chapter Two: Photographic Memory of the Sexual Violence

Photographs play a crucial role beyond being mere visual representations, as they have the power to shape, challenge, or disrupt individual and collective memories within a nation.¹⁷⁹

Camera images, although incomplete, spark conversations about their ability to comprehend or

contrast with more detailed historical narratives, enabling them to stand on equal footing with comprehensive written records. The widespread use of cameras, their accessibility, and the photographs they produce offer valuable opportunities for everyone to take part in a nation's memory. In fact, certain photographs often become iconic symbols representing national narratives.¹⁸⁰ In Bangladesh, the archival photographs of *biranganas* are vivid and moving artifacts that work as a visual documentation of the hardship these women experienced during the War of 1971. These photographs highlight the resilience and sorrows of these women as survivors, while also calling attention to the covert silences these victims had to endure in postwar Bangladesh. In addition to capturing the distinct individual memories of the victims in these photos, they enable us to comprehend how Bangladesh as a nation remembers these women today.

There are difficulties in the ways photographs shape the past. Photographic images seem to contain memory, which appears to respond to our gaze by telling a story. Since their invention, photographs have been linked to the idea of memory and loss, according to Marita Struken.¹⁸¹

The camera is a piece of technology that reconstructs the past and records photographic memories. However, memories are created by a camera rather than existing independently in a

¹⁷⁹ Marita Struken, *Tangled Memories: The Vietnam War, The Aids Epidemic, and The Politics of Remembering* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1997), 19.

¹⁸⁰ Struken, *Tangled Memories*, 20.

¹⁸¹ Struken, *Tangled Memories*, 19.

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photograph. Photographs may give structure to history and personal experiences, frequently serving as the material proof that supports claims of authenticity, but they also have the power to capture the unreachable.¹⁸²

The link between photographic memory and history can produce different results: it can create new memories as well as obliterate them. In the process of producing new memories, there is always something that is forgotten.¹⁸³ By freezing time, photographs document both specific events and omit other actions or inactions that have not been captured using a camera. In this context, photographs serve as a powerful tool for bearing witness to war atrocities. Bearing witness helps collective remembering by interpreting historical events as significant and requiring critical attention. At the same time, by capturing war atrocities, photographs facilitate truth telling and emphasize the importance of collectively acknowledging and addressing such events.¹⁸⁴ Additionally, it supports Maurice Halbwachs's argument that memory is created not by an individual's own conscious mind, but rather, by a collective awareness that shapes it to the goals of people using it in the present.¹⁸⁵ For instance, the photographs of the Second World War concentration camps, widely named as "atrocities photos" by postwar critics, not only help to remember the Holocaust (1941–45), but also to develop a conscious sense of understanding contemporary instances of atrocity.¹⁸⁶ This is a memory practice that allows people who were not present during the event to experience the Holocaust personally, in part through photographs. Thus, while viewing the pictorial depictions of the atrocity in Rwanda (1994) or Bosnia (1992–95) in different media or exhibitions, viewers often use memories of the Second World War as a

¹⁸² Struken, *Tangled Memories*, 19–20.

¹⁸³ Struken, *Tangled Memories*, 19–20.

¹⁸⁴ Barbie Zelizer, *Remembering to forget: Holocaust memory through the camera's eye* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998), 10–13.

¹⁸⁵ Maurice Halbwachs, *The Collective Memory* (NY: Harper & Row, 1980), 69.

¹⁸⁶ Zelizer, *Remembering*, 1.

backdrop or context.¹⁸⁷ Therein lies the photograph's ability to serve as a memory-container, that is, a potent foundational element for the past that links the unimaginable to the imagined. The

photographs of the Holocaust have had a complex impact on society. On one hand, these photographs serve as a reminder of the horrors of the past, helping to prevent us from forgetting the atrocities. On the other hand, they also raise moral concerns about our responsibilities to address current atrocities.¹⁸⁸

The available photographs of the 1971 Liberation War of Bangladesh play a complex role in recording the history of the war and the atrocities inflicted upon women in 1971. Unlike written accounts, these photographs vividly capture the horror of the war and bear witness to the untold individual stories through visualization, creating a public assumption of responsibility. It reminds the new generation about events that have been ignored in mainstream media and literary works. However, as an inevitable consequence of preserving and presenting these old photographs, they are limited to representing a partial image of the history of sexual violence.

The 1971 Liberation War was captured in photographs by many local and foreign photographers.

Most of the local photographers were relatively young in 1971 and some of them intended to make photography their profession. Following the declaration of independence, a few of them rose to fame as photographers. Some of the renowned Bengali photographers who visually documented the Liberation War are Naibuddin Ahmed, Rashid Talukder, Abdul Hamid Raihan, Aftab Ahmed, Jalaluddin Haider, Mohammad Shafi, Sayeeda Khanom, Golam Mawla, and Mukaddes Ali. They exhibited remarkable bravery by going into the battle zone armed with their cameras. Their courageous determination to capture the suffering and gore of the war has

¹⁸⁷ Zelizer, *Remembering*, 10–13.

¹⁸⁸ Zelizer, *Remembering*, 12–13.

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resulted in our now possessing the photographs as an essential physical record of the Liberation

War.¹⁸⁹

Naibuddin Ahmed is perhaps the most well-known among all the Bengali photographers. He captured many photos of the war that were published on numerous international platforms and publicized around the world. Working as a principal researcher photographer at the East Pakistan Agricultural University, Ahmed once cleverly deceived the Pakistani army by secretly capturing images of torture and violence while pretending to fix a malfunctioning camera. The lens of the camera was blocked, but Ahmed discovered that the camera was operating perfectly. He then secretly shot pictures of surrounding buildings that had been set on fire and regular people being tortured at the camp while feigning that it was still not in operation. He asked permission to bring the camera home from the army officer so he could use the appropriate tools to fix it. The next day, he returned the camera, but Ahmed kept the film he used to take those photographs. After the reel was developed, Ahmed sent all the photographs to Colonel Taher, the sector 11 commander.¹⁹⁰ Some of his photographs were published in the *Washington Post*. Despite facing backlash from the Pakistani army, Ahmed's impactful photographs shed light on the suffering of women and civilians in Bangladesh, leaving a lasting impression on the international community. Those published photographs damaged Pakistan's claim of "normalcy," as they exposed to the international community the daily atmosphere of terror happening in

¹⁸⁹ "Capturing History," *Londoni*, last modified October 5, 2017, <http://www.londoni.co/index.php/23-history-of-bangladesh/1971-muktijuddho/157-muktijuddho-bangladesh-liberation-war-1971-capturing-history-bengali-photographer-history-of-bangladesh>.

¹⁹⁰ "A photographer looks back at 1971," *The Daily Star*, accessed March 11, 2023, <https://www.thedailystar.net/news-detail-65606>.

Bangladesh.¹⁹¹ After witnessing the horror of the war, Ahmed was so disturbed by the atrocity that he gave up photography as a profession.

This chapter engages with a diverse set of archival photographs, including Naibuddin Ahmed's iconic "hair photograph," that capture the sexual violence of 1971, and its impact on women. These photographs were collected from different archives during my research trip in Bangladesh as well as from different online sources.¹⁹² I have analyzed these photographs based on their historical relevance and theoretical connections. These photographs bear witness to those forgotten memories that are integral to understanding the history of the war. By forgotten memories, I refer to the layers of silence concerning a *birangana*'s identity, public perceptions, and the moral and social stigmas attached to abortion and the adoption of war babies (who were products of sexual assault). The analysis of some of these iconic and haunting photographs not only gives an insight into the public perception of the victims of sexual violence in Bangladesh, but also invites us to question from where such embedded ideas developed. The dominant patriarchal viewpoints in society are maintained, I argue, through the symbolic meanings these photos carry. By following photographs from the moment of their creation to their subsequent incorporation into archives and deployment in the construction of narratives, this chapter tracks both silence and violence throughout the record's many uses. Here, silence and violence are interconnected by the same underlaying issue. The central theoretical argument in this chapter suggests that the ways in which these photographs establish a collective memory are interconnected with other portrayals of *biranganas*, particularly in the context of symbolic

¹⁹¹ "A photographer looks back at 1971," *The Daily Star*, accessed March 11, 2023, <https://www.thedailystar.net/news-detail-65606>.

¹⁹² It is important to note that the Bangladeshi government has designated the 1971 Liberation War photographs as a priceless component of the country's public and national history. These pictures can be used by anyone as long as proper credit is provided.

violence. In short, my aim is to understand the image of a *birangana* that is influenced by the visual representation of these photographs and how that affects the collective memory.

The Iconic Hair Photograph

In 1971, a photograph (see Figure 1) captured by Bangladeshi photographer Naibuddin Ahmed spurred public discussion and drew global attention to the barbaric sexual violence that was being committed against women in Bangladesh. Ahmed took this photo of a woman at the East Pakistan Agricultural University in Mymensingh. The woman in the photograph was one of millions of sexually assaulted victims by the Pakistani army.¹⁹³ In the photograph, the most striking fact is that the victim is seen covering her face with her fists. Her hair is disheveled and messy. She seems to be in a state of shock and pain. It symbolizes the psychological effect of sexual violence on its victim.

The woman who is trying to hide her identity out of shame and fear is the focal point of the photograph. Despite her obscured face, the intense emotion she is experiencing is palpable, effectively communicating her deep frustration through her defensive posture. Her posture in this photograph is a visual representation of the social and psychological effects of the atrocities carried out on innocent Bengali women during the war. John Tulloch referred to this photograph as “classical a pose as any Madonna and Child.”¹⁹⁴ In this photograph, the victim’s urge to cover her face with fists and tousled hair is symbolic in many ways; as John Tulloch suggests, the photograph has the capacity to reveal or suggest what is unsayable.¹⁹⁵ The image became an

¹⁹³ Brownmiller, *Against Our Will*, 80–81.

¹⁹⁴ John Tulloch and Richard Blood, “Iconic photojournalism and absent images: Democratization and memories of terror,” in *The Routledge Companion to News and Journalism*, ed. Stuart Allan (London: Routledge, 2010), 513. ¹⁹⁵

John Tulloch and Richard Blood, *Icons of War and Terror: Media Images in an Age of International Risk* (London: Routledge, 2012), 54–55.

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iconic photograph after it was exhibited and used on many public platforms and popularized in Western media, including the photographic exhibition in London titled “Bangladesh 1971,” and in *The Washington Post* and *The Guardian*.¹⁹⁶



Figure 1. The iconic hair photograph by Naibuddin Ahmed, Liberation War Museum, Dhaka, Bangladesh, Gallery 4. Used With Permission.

Iconic photographs refer to powerful photographs with symbolic meanings of singular historical events that have been widely reproduced and circulated by the media, thereby catalyzing public debate. Iconic photographs also have the capacity to shape collective memory of the event and represent an era or historical theme for subsequent generations. They also work

¹⁹⁶ Mookherjee, “The raped woman,” 6.

as a formal blueprint for other images in later periods that produce similar concepts.¹⁹⁷ In this context, this photograph in which the faceless victim’s hair dominates has become the formal blueprint for images that capture the sexual violence and victimization of women in contemporary Bangladesh.

During the war, the hair photograph was first published in *The Washington Post*, a popular platform that drew international attention to the fact that women are subject to sexual violence in Bangladesh by men of the Pakistani army. In 2008, it was exhibited in London with the following caption: “One of the estimated 400,000 *birangana*, meaning ‘brave women,’ who were raped during the war.”¹⁹⁸ Not only in exhibitions, but it has also been used in many national and international film festivals, posters, documentaries, and newspaper or online articles symbolizing victims of sexual assaults in 1971. This iconic photograph is also displayed in Gallery 4 at the Liberation War Museum in Dhaka and listed in muktijuddho e-archive. Here, what I will refer to as the “hair photograph” bears witness to the sexual violence of 1971 by drawing the critical attention of the public visiting the museum or browsing the e-archive. By doing so, it constitutes a form of collective memory.

Bearing witness is an approach that facilitates the recovery process for individuals who experienced tragic events by establishing a collective understanding. It involves taking responsibility for what they see, transitioning from individual perception to embracing both an individual and collective position.¹⁹⁹ The act of bearing witness can be facilitated by photographic images. However, visuals can only be useful up until a certain point in the

¹⁹⁷ Akiba Cohen, Sandrine Boudana and Paul Frosh, “You must remember this: Iconic news photographs and collective memory,” *Journal of Communication* 68, no. 3 (2018): 453–455.

¹⁹⁸ Mookherjee, “The raped woman,” 6.

¹⁹⁹ Zelizer, *Remembering*, 10.

development of presumptions regarding atrocities. As Barbie Zelizer argues, while photographs might be important in establishing a collective understanding of what is morally acceptable, they are usually prohibited from public exhibition until the nation in question is prepared to openly acknowledge the committed atrocities.²⁰⁰

The “hair photograph” depicts the way a sexually assaulted victim is perceived in Bangladesh, especially in rural areas. People remember and describe sexually transgressed victims through such phrases as “horrific scene” marked by their “disheveled hair,” “her loud laughter,” or her “quietness,” “muteness,” “the one who stares into space,” with “deadened eyes.”²⁰¹ These terms reflect how symbolic perceptions and power dynamics in society shape a social narrative based on gender, leading to the formation of collective acceptance.²⁰² Nayanika Mookherjee asserts that the dissemination of this hair photograph and other visual representations of victims of sexual violence in 1971 highlights the existence of a collective memory regarding wartime sexual atrocities. During her fieldwork in rural Bangladesh to collect oral testimonies of *biranganas*, Mookherjee encountered many questions referring to the iconic hair photograph, such as: “Have you seen ‘the famous hair photograph?’ The raped woman covering her face with her fist and hair? The women we saw looked very much like that. They had become “abnormal” (mentally unstable) after the assault.”²⁰³ This comment emphasizes the importance of visually identifying the victim. The collective memory of wartime sexual violence in Bangladesh identifies the victim as abnormal or mentally unstable. Mookherjee further states that such identification makes *birangana* a complex figure whose identity is shaped by both real

²⁰⁰ Zelizer, *Remembering*, 11.

²⁰¹ Leesa Gazi, “Matir duniya shunte ki pai?” *Bangladesh News*, March 25, 2014, <http://arts.bdnews24.com/?p=5766>.

²⁰² Pierre Bourdieu, *Language and Symbolic Power* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1991), 166.

²⁰³ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, xvi.

life experiences and representations in literature and visual media.²⁰⁴ In this process, the victim loses her true identity and becomes a symbol of shame.

To understand how shame is associated with a sexual assault victim’s identity, we need to conceptualize the patriarchal culture of South Asia. In the patriarchal society of South Asia, the concepts of honour and shame are interconnected; although, these two terms have contrasting meanings. Honour is a gendered notion that refers to the fact that men possess intrinsic honour and have the authority to impose power and regulate women’s conduct. On the other hand, women possess only shame and they are the repositories of men’s honour. This conceptualization produces inequality. Thus, shame (*shorom* in Bangla) can be considered a gendered equivalent within the concept of honour, rather than its binary opposite.²⁰⁵

In Bangladesh, patriarchy is deeply ingrained in the social structure, allowing men to exert dominance over women through control of resources and power. This system is rooted in the ownership of resources by men, which renders women dependent and weak. The unequal distribution of labour, property, and financial resources further solidifies men’s dominant position and perpetuates the cycle of patriarchy.²⁰⁶ Such gendered positioning deprives women of their social power and autonomy over their own lives. Men are the controllers of women’s lives, whereas a woman’s worth lies in her virtue and chastity. In a society like this, sexual violence carries multiple symbolic meanings. This masculine dominance is an act of symbolic violence. Here, I refer to Pierre Bourdieu’s concept of symbolic violence, which encompasses all forms of

²⁰⁴ Mookherjee, *The Spectral Wound*, xvi.

²⁰⁵ Manisha Gupte, "The Role of 'Honor' in Violence against South Asian Women in the United States," in *Manavi Occasional Paper* No. 11, ed. Shamita Das Dasgupta & Sujata Warriar (NJ: Manavi, 2015): 1. ²⁰⁶ Mead Cain, Syeda Rokeya Khanam, and Shamsun Nahar. "Class, Patriarchy, and Women's Work in Bangladesh," *Population and Development Review* 5, no. 3 (1979): 406. <https://doi.org/10.2307/1972079>.

power relations in society based on hierarchy, subordination, and dominance. In this context, male dominance is established through practical recognition and doxic or normative acceptance in Bangladesh. According to Bourdieu, *doxa* represents an underlying assumption or belief that is deeply ingrained in a society and shapes how individuals understand and interpret the social world. It can be compared to shared sense or traditional knowledge that influences people's beliefs.²⁰⁷ In this particular context, traditional societies such as Bangladesh adhere to patriarchal norms that are seen to be rooted in common sense. These norms establish a clear social hierarchy and define gender relations, with the dominant group being men. Sexual and other types of physical or direct violence against women are thus an expression of "symbolic" power.²⁰⁸ As Bourdieu states, "[h]onouring a vital symbolic good is firmly connected to notions of manliness or virility and domestic, legal and educational strategies for controlling kinswomen."²⁰⁹ In short, the notion of what we call "manliness" also refers to the way men defend their dominant position when it is under attack.

In 1971, Pakistani soldiers committed acts of sexual assault against Bengali women, aiming to undermine the dominant position of Bengali men and challenge their sense of honour tied to women's chastity. This attack was viewed as a public shame, not only for the victim herself but also for her husband, father, family and the entire society. Consequently, the victims and their families affected by the sexual violence were hesitant to disclose the identities of the victims or openly discuss the situation due to the prevailing societal stereotypes. Nilima Ibrahim's

statement on the plight of these victims reflects such inherent masculine superiority. She states that countrymen would have preferred seeing the dead bodies of women victims,

²⁰⁷ Bourdieu, *Masculine Domination*, 34.

²⁰⁸ Bourdieu, *Masculine Domination*, 30–34.

²⁰⁹ Bourdieu, *Masculine Domination*, 48.

rather than finding them living and breathing.²¹⁰ The photograph (see figure 1) by Naibuddin Ahmed exemplifies this masculine response regarding women's place in a patriarchal society. The victim in the photograph is seen covering her face with her fists, a gesture believed to be an attempt to hide her identity. This action is attributed to societal gender norms that associate a loss of dignity and virtue with victims of sexual violence. The victim's fear of public shaming and the dishonour brought upon the men responsible for her plight are also highlighted. The photograph thus serves as a powerful symbol representing numerous other victims who, like her, choose to remain silent in order to maintain a normal life. The caption below this photo at the Liberation War Museum adds to such confusion:

For the most part, this issue has been brushed aside, since it requires us to look within ourselves, at the strictures and structures of our own society as well as to condemn the brutality of the other. Clearly the ambiguous figure of the *birangona* (the shamed one) cannot be easily contained within a generalized glorious narrative of the nation.²¹¹

Nayanika Mookherjee argues that this photograph creates confusion and bewilderment by referring to *biranganas* as both ambiguous figures and shamed individuals. The statement suggests that there are conflicting perceptions society holds towards them as the description differs from popular definition of the word *birangana*. Unlike other materials displayed at the museum, this photo does not have any Bengali translation of the text.²¹² People visiting the museum, especially children and teenagers today, often ask questions like: Why is the victim covering her face? What is she hiding? What has she done? What is her name and where does she

belong?²¹³ Such questioning indicates how these women are remembered (and forgotten)

collectively today, referring to the fact that the memory of this violence is often suppressed in the

²¹⁰ Nilima Ibrahim, *A war heroine, I speak*, trans. Fayeza Hasanat (Dhaka: Bangla Academy, 2017), 57.

²¹¹ Mookherjee, "The raped woman," 12.

²¹² Mookherjee, "The raped woman," 12.

²¹³ Mookherjee, "The raped woman," 12.

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current generation through various methods, like avoiding translating the details of the woman's fate into Bengali.

The hair photograph captures the complex and often contradictory social dynamics that women in Bangladesh face, highlighting their subordinate position in society.²¹⁴ It sheds light on the challenges faced by survivors of sexual assault, who often encounter difficulties speaking out due to societal pressures. In many cases, families, including fathers and spouses, were unsupportive and chose to hide incidents of abduction by Pakistani soldiers. Some victims were even abandoned by their families because of family honour. Bina D'Costa further explains this behaviour with her own experience as an interviewer. D'Costa writes that even though she assured families about her purely academic intentions in recording victim's testimonies, they were not cooperative in providing details about those victims or their whereabouts.²¹⁵ In rural Bangladesh, there are many victims whose stories were never recorded because they chose to remain silent due to social stigma and fear of public shaming. Thus, in accordance with Trouillot's theory, the photographic representations of *birangana* are marked by a number of silences. To begin with, not all victims of sexual violence were documented in photographs. In addition, archives contain a limited number of photographs that document their victimization in 1971. There is no visual or written documentation available about those lost victims. Insufficient information offers a challenge in establishing verifiable evidence of their victimization.

Consequently, the attention given to these iconic photographs of *birangana* silences numerous unidentified and undocumented victims.

²¹⁴ D’Costa, “Birangona,” 81.

²¹⁵ D’Costa, “Birangona,” 111.

Victims Lay like Corpses

Another haunting picture of a *birangana* by Naibuddin Ahmed has many social meanings and silences attached to it. The photograph (see figure 2), taken near the Mymensingh Agricultural University, portrays the woman lying next to bunkers with bystanders milling around her. The victim’s unbuttoned and torn blouse, emotionless expression, disheveled hair just like the woman in the first photograph (see Figure 1), and bruised body all serve as poignant symbols of the horror and helplessness experienced by sexual assault survivors. All these factors indicate her physical and psychological struggles.



Figure 2. Women discovered in bunker by Naibuddin Ahmed, muktijuddho e-archive (<https://www.liberationwarbangladesh.org/>). Used with Permission.

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According to Naibuddin Ahmed's statement recorded by Rahnuma Ahmed, he received the news of corpse-like girls being 'discovered' beside bunkers next to the Bangladesh Agricultural University, Mymensingh on December 12, 1971. The Pakistani army had established a camp there in April, where women were kept and tortured. On December 12, when the army left Mymensingh, people discovered assaulted women in horrific condition. Upon receiving the news, Naibuddin went there and found people gathering there to witness the victim, who had already turned into a curious object for the audience. He took this photograph of the victim who was not fully conscious at that time. Ahmed approached the woman, but she did not

respond. She was tied to the pole behind her, in a defenseless state.²¹⁶

This photograph (see Figure 2) is a symbolic visualization of the magnitude of torture Pakistani soldiers carried out on Bengali women. In her book *Against Our Will: Men, Women and Rape*, Susan Brownmiller revealed that there was evidence that some women were sexually assaulted nearly 80 times in one night by the Pakistani army. The total number of female victims is still a debated issue.²¹⁷ It is estimated that approximately 200,000 to 400,000 women were sexually abused during the nine months of the war in 1971.²¹⁸ The International Planned Parenthood Federation (IPPF) and the United Nations sent Geoffrey Davis, an Australian physician to Dhaka in 1971 to perform late-term abortions and allow widespread foreign adoption of the war children born to Bangladeshi mothers. In response to a question on whether the numbers of women who were sexually assaulted by the Pakistani military were correct, Davis

²¹⁶ Rahnuma Ahmed, “Bangladesh: Woman Recovered from Pak Army Bunker in December 1971,” accessed March 15, 2023. <https://alaiwah.wordpress.com/2008/04/10/bangladesh-woman-recovered-from-pak-army-bunker-in-december-1971/>.”

²¹⁷ Susan Brownmiller and Geoffrey Davis give an estimation of the total number of women who were sexually harassed by the Pakistani army in 1971. The exact number is still unknown, because it is unclear from these estimates if multiple perpetrators and recurrent victimization are taken into consideration. ²¹⁸ Brownmiller, *Against Our Will*, 80–81.

stated that approximately 400,000 women were sexually abused following the military crackdown.²¹⁹ In order for Bangladesh to demonstrate the magnitude of the violence committed against women in 1971 and to legitimize the postwar strategies, it was crucial to come up with a definite estimate. The politics of numbers also created a layer of silence between the people who produced the information and the collective remembering of the war in Bangladesh.

The Pakistani army used the “hit-and-run” strategy to subjugate the Bengali population. Hit-and-run subjugation refers to the brutality of forcing male or other family members to watch

the sexual transgression of their female family members by Pakistani soldiers. Many of these victims and their families were murdered. Some were taken away and kept in captivity as sex slaves.²²⁰ Not only in this photograph (see Figure 2), but also many other archival photographs (see Figures 3 and 4) of the war portray how brutal the female victimization was in 1971.



Figure 3. Victim of Sexual Violence, muktijuddho e-archive (<https://www.liberationwarbangladesh.org/>). Used With Permission.

²¹⁹ Bina D’Costa, “1971: Rape and its consequences, an in-depth interview with Dr. Geoffrey Davis,” *Bdnews24.com*, December 15, 2010, <https://opinion.bdnews24.com/2010/12/15/1971-rape-and-its-consequences/>. Accessed on 1 February 2023.

²²⁰ Pai, “The 1971 East Pakistan,” 4.